ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · October 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A	Salt Lake City	71.6
#2	A	Raleigh	70.7
#3	A	St. Louis	69.1
#4	A	Las Vegas	69.1
#5	A-	Austin	67.9
#6	A-	Charlotte	67.2
#7	A-	Hartford	67.1

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Detroit	19.0
#49	D	Chicago	26.5
#48	D	Louisville	28.7
#47	D	Grand Rapids	29.6
#46	C-	Jacksonville	31.6
#45	C-	Indianapolis	32.1
#44	C-	Fresno	33.8

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	9 cities
B+ / B / B-	15 cities
C+ / C / C-	22 cities
D	4 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · October 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	**Salt Lake City** Salt Lake City-Murray	A	71.6	3.7%	+4.5%	+2.5%	+0.3%	58 days
2	**Raleigh** Raleigh-Cary	A	70.7	3.1%	+3.2%	+2.2%	-1.6%	59 days
3	**St. Louis** St. Louis	A	69.1	3.9%	+3.5%	+0.7%	-1.3%	50 days
4	**Las Vegas** Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A	69.1	4.8%	+4.2%	+1.5%	-0.2%	58 days
5	**Austin** Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	67.9	3.9%	+5.1%	+1.2%	+0.6%	80 days
6	**Charlotte** Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A-	67.2	3.7%	+4.2%	+1.5%	-1.5%	N/A
7	**Hartford** Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A-	67.1	2.7%	+5.3%	+1.9%	+2.8%	35 days
8	**Cincinnati** Cincinnati	A-	67.0	3.6%	+8.1%	+0.3%	-1.4%	44 days
9	**Philadelphia** Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	A-	65.9	4.4%	+2.1%	+0.8%	+1.2%	49 days
10	**Kansas City** Kansas City	B+	61.3	3.9%	+7.3%	+0.7%	-2.1%	50 days
11	**Dallas** Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B+	61.2	4.4%	+4.0%	+1.0%	+0.6%	62 days
12	**Baltimore** Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B+	60.5	3.9%	+6.0%	-0.5%	-0.5%	46 days
13	**Orlando** Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B+	60.2	4.6%	+6.1%	+0.8%	+0.4%	77 days
14	**Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh	B	58.6	3.9%	+3.3%	-0.1%	+1.1%	54 days
15	**Seattle** Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	57.6	4.8%	+5.4%	+0.9%	-0.5%	51 days
16	**Tampa** Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	54.8	4.7%	+5.1%	+0.9%	+0.3%	76 days
17	**Los Angeles** Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	53.9	4.8%	+3.4%	+1.8%	-1.9%	55 days
18	**Miami** Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	53.9	3.7%	+7.7%	+0.3%	+0.4%	85 days
19	**Columbus** Columbus	B-	52.8	3.3%	+4.2%	+0.1%	-2.2%	48 days
20	**Atlanta** Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B-	51.8	3.4%	+3.1%	-0.5%	+1.2%	60 days
21	**San Antonio** San Antonio-New Braunfels	B-	51.2	4.5%	+3.7%	+0.5%	+0.2%	71 days
22	**Nashville** Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	B-	51.1	3.2%	+3.9%	+0.7%	-1.3%	62 days
23	**Cleveland** Cleveland	B-	50.7	3.4%	+0.9%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
24	**Washington DC** Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	50.4	3.8%	+5.8%	-2.0%	-3.6%	43 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	**San Francisco** San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	C+	49.7	4.6%	+5.8%	+0.6%	-2.3%	37 days
26	**Houston** Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	C+	48.5	5.0%	+1.2%	+1.3%	+0.6%	55 days
27	**Birmingham** Birmingham	C+	48.2	3.4%	+0.0%	+0.9%	-1.3%	61 days
28	**Oklahoma City** Oklahoma City	C+	46.6	3.9%	+4.2%	+0.7%	-1.6%	57 days
29	**Boston** Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C+	45.0	3.9%	+2.9%	-0.1%	+2.9%	43 days
30	**Providence** Providence-Warwick	C+	44.7	4.3%	+3.1%	+0.6%	+1.7%	39 days
31	**Phoenix** Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	44.6	4.9%	+3.3%	+0.9%	-2.9%	62 days
32	**Portland** Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C+	44.6	4.9%	+5.7%	-1.5%	+0.1%	66 days
33	**San Jose** San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	C	42.4	4.3%	-0.8%	+1.6%	-1.1%	35 days
34	**Virginia Beach** Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C	41.2	3.7%	+5.5%	-0.6%	-2.6%	44 days
35	**New York** New York Newark-Jersey City	C	39.9	4.7%	+1.9%	+0.5%	-0.1%	56 days
36	**Minneapolis** Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	39.8	4.7%	+0.3%	+1.4%	-1.8%	42 days
37	**Sacramento** Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	38.9	5.2%	+2.0%	+0.8%	-1.5%	51 days
38	**San Diego** San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C	38.7	4.9%	+7.5%	+0.7%	-2.1%	46 days
39	**Milwaukee** Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	38.0	3.8%	+0.5%	-0.2%	+1.6%	37 days
40	**Denver** Denver-Aurora-Centennial	C-	36.5	4.6%	+2.1%	+0.1%	-3.0%	58 days
41	**Riverside** Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C-	35.3	5.9%	+5.5%	+0.8%	-1.7%	64 days
42	**Richmond** Richmond	C-	35.3	3.6%	+2.4%	-0.8%	-2.6%	44 days
43	**Memphis** Memphis	C-	35.2	4.6%	+4.5%	-0.5%	-2.8%	72 days
44	**Fresno** Fresno	C-	33.8	7.8%	+4.5%	+0.8%	-1.3%	58 days
45	**Indianapolis** Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C-	32.1	3.3%	+0.6%	-1.1%	-1.9%	53 days
46	**Jacksonville** Jacksonville	C-	31.6	4.8%	+1.3%	+0.1%	-0.6%	66 days
47	**Grand Rapids** Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	D	29.6	4.2%	+1.4%	+0.7%	-7.2%	42 days
48	**Louisville** Louisville-Jefferson County	D	28.7	4.1%	+1.7%	-0.1%	-0.8%	45 days
49	**Chicago** Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	D	26.5	5.2%	+3.3%	+0.2%	-3.1%	36 days
50	**Detroit** Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	D	19.0	5.7%	+1.5%	-0.2%	-1.8%	43 days

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

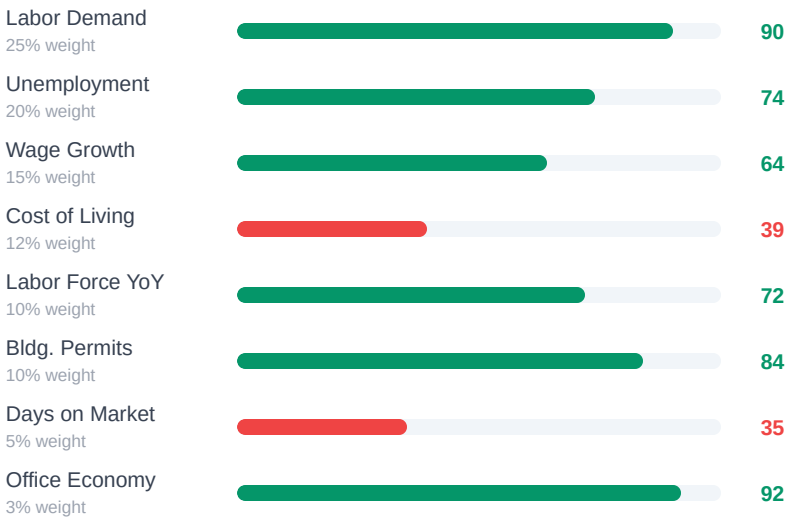
A

VERY GOOD

71.6th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+2.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.3%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+28.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **58 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Salt Lake City-Murray has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 71.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, driven by a 90th percentile labor demand composite score and a 92nd percentile office economy share. The city's labor market is characterized by a 2.49% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.398% weekly hours deviation from its own trend. These numbers signal a genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running slightly below trend, indicating a healthy and sustainable labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 2.49% and weekly hours deviation of -0.398% combine to signal a genuine demand expansion, with the city adding jobs at a rate above the national average and hours worked being slightly below trend. This indicates that the labor market is growing, but not at an unsustainable pace. The labor demand composite score of 7.39 puts the city in the top tier, at the 90th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% is relatively low, ranking in the 74th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that it may be moderately challenging to find qualified candidates, and wage pressure may be present. However, the market is not extremely tight, and hiring is still feasible.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.49% is above average, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but they can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.67, based on $262 per square foot and $39.26 per hour, Salt Lake City-Murray ranks in the 39th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums to offset the higher cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.35% year-over-year, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a slowly expanding labor pool. This implies that the hiring capacity is increasing, but at a moderate pace, and businesses may need to be patient when looking to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 28.20%, ranking in the 84th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 58 days, with a 0% year-over-year change, ranking in the 35th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not becoming more competitive.

Office Economy

With an office economy share of 4.32, ranking in the 92nd percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray has a deep and specialized professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, it may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which may require a different type of workforce.

In conclusion, Salt Lake City-Murray offers businesses a strong labor market, a deep professional talent pool, and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to grow and attract top talent. However, the relatively high cost of living and tight labor market may require businesses to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract and retain workers, which is the single biggest risk or constraint that decision-makers should factor in.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

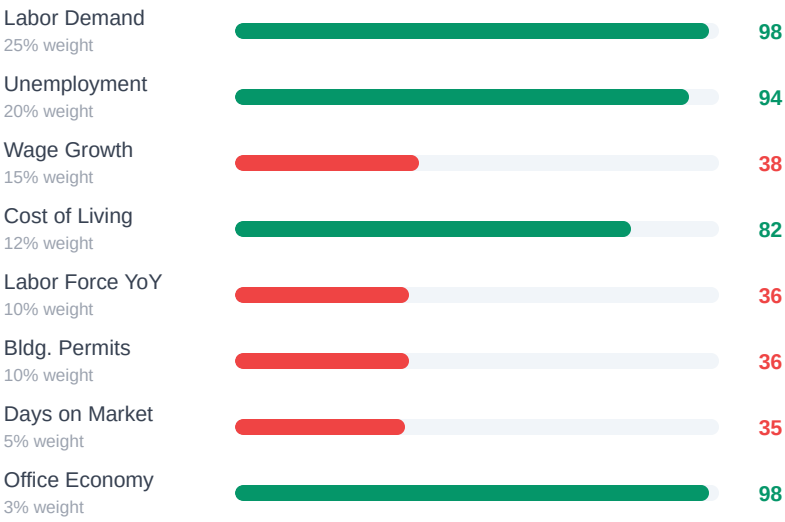
A

VERY GOOD

70.7th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.1%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+2.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-5.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **59 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 70.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, scoring 98th percentile in both employment growth and office economy. The labor demand composite score is 8.63, indicating a top-tier performance. This suggests that the city is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with employment growth of 2.23% and weekly hours 1.207% above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 2.23% and hours deviation of 1.207% above trend signal genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a strong and growing economy. This combination suggests that businesses are hiring and expanding, creating new opportunities for workers. The labor demand composite score of 8.63 reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.10% is relatively low, ranking in the 94th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 3.16% is below average, ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. While this may be beneficial for workers' purchasing power, it also means that businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $213/sqft and hourly earnings of $38.60, resulting in a ratio of 5.52, is relatively affordable, ranking in the 82nd percentile. This means that the city offers a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.2% YoY further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.63% year-over-year, ranking in the 36th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This suggests that the city may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the supply of workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -5.68%, ranking in the 36th percentile, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This suggests that the city may face future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased competition for housing and higher costs for workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 59 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, ranking in the 35th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible. Workers relocating to the city may face a moderate level of competition for housing, but the market is not overly challenging.

Office Economy

The city's professional talent pool is deep, ranking in the 98th percentile, with a share of 4.54 out of 5. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high level of specialized knowledge and skills. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies in the tech and finance sectors. However, the city's shrinking labor pool and tightening housing supply pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should factor in, potentially requiring strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs. Overall, the city's strengths make it a competitive location, but its weaknesses require careful consideration and planning.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

St. Louis

St. Louis

A

VERY GOOD

69.1th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.3%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+18.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **50 days** median, +8.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 69.1th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and highly affordable cost of living being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, scoring 78th and 98th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.44 and cost of living ratio of $163/sqft to $38.11/hr, with a PSF decline of 1.8% YoY, signal a favorable business environment. With these metrics, St. Louis presents a unique blend of economic growth and affordability.

Labor Demand

St. Louis exhibits a labor demand composite score of 6.44, driven by employment growth of 0.68% YoY and weekly hours 1.193% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a healthy and growing economy. The above-average scores in both employment growth and hours worked suggest a strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis stands at 3.90%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a skilled and engaged workforce, which can be beneficial for companies looking to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in St. Louis is moderate, with a year-over-year increase of 3.51%, placing it near the median at the 48th percentile. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while workers are experiencing a modest increase in purchasing power. As a result, businesses can expect to see some upward pressure on labor costs, but it is manageable.

Cost of Living

St. Louis is highly affordable, with a cost of living ratio of $163/sqft to $38.11/hr and a PSF decline of 1.8% YoY, earning it a 98th percentile rank. This high affordability score means that the city offers a significant talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand. The declining PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is contracting at a rate of -1.33% YoY, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract talent from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in St. Louis are increasing by 18.07% YoY, ranking in the 66th percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which should help maintain affordability and support workforce accommodation. As a result, the city is likely to remain an attractive location for workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in St. Louis is 50 days, with an 8.7% YoY increase, ranking in the 74th percentile. This slower market means that relocating workers may find it easier to find and purchase a home, as properties are not being snapped up as quickly as in other cities. However, this also suggests a slightly more buyer-friendly market, which could impact housing prices and affordability.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a professional and office worker share of 2.64, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and office skills, but may not be the best fit for those seeking a highly specialized or dominant tech/finance talent pool. As a result, companies in industries like consulting, finance, or headquarters operations may find St. Louis an attractive location.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, highly affordable cost of living, and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for relocation or expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor force supply, which may pose challenges for hiring and talent attraction in the long term.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #4 OF 50

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

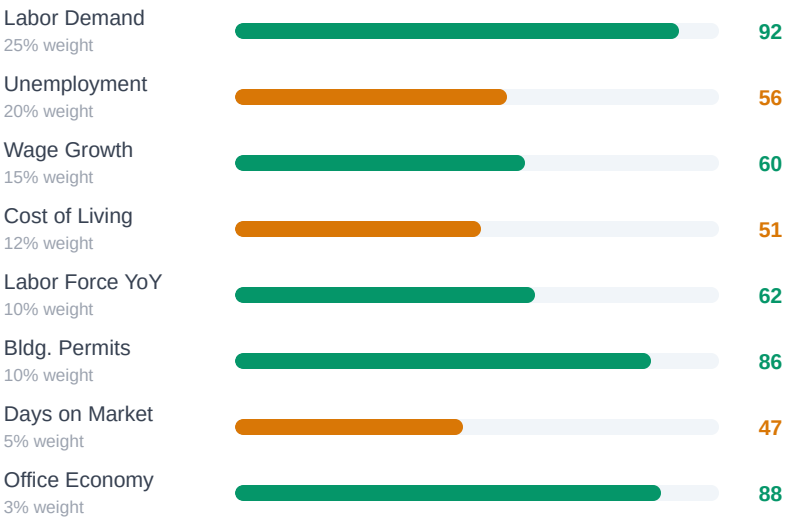
A

VERY GOOD

69.1th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+28.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **58 days** median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 69.1th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep office economy talent pool defining its current economic character. The labor demand composite score of 7.44, driven by a 1.46% employment growth rate and a 1.098% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a robust job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.46% and weekly hours deviation of 1.098% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a combination that suggests a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.44, ranking in the 92nd percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.80% ranks in the 56th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This means that while the market is not extremely tight, it is still relatively competitive, and businesses may face some challenges in hiring. However, the unemployment rate is not high enough to indicate a significant surplus of available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.21% ranks in the 60th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing. While this may put some upward pressure on wages, it is not excessively high.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Las Vegas, with a PSF of $259/sqft and an earnings ratio of 7.77, ranks in the 51st percentile, indicating a near-median level of affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.0% year-over-year relative to wages suggests that the city is becoming more affordable, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of -0.21% year-over-year, ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating a slight contraction in the labor force supply. This suggests that the hiring capacity may be somewhat constrained, although the negative growth rate is relatively modest.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 28.53%, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.8%, ranking in the 47th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor excessively slow, making it accessible for relocating workers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.86, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, a deep office economy talent pool, and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to grow. However, the slight contraction in labor force supply and moderate wage growth rate are factors that decision-makers should consider when evaluating this city as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #5 OF 50

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

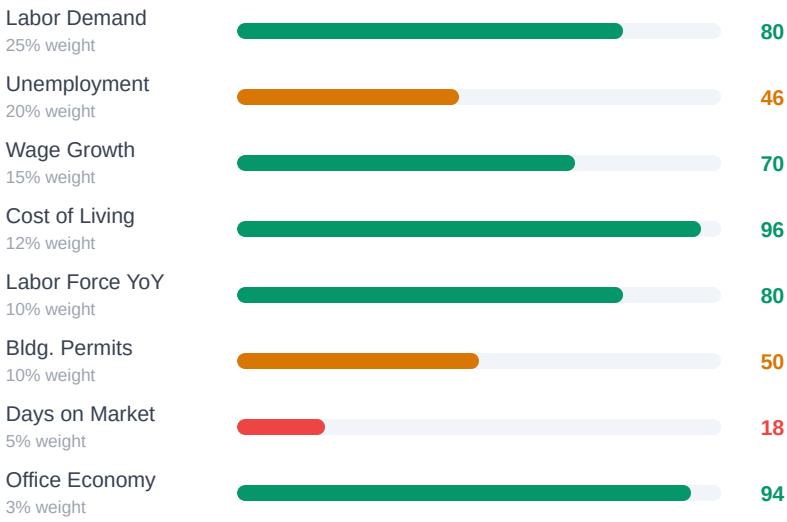
A-

GOOD

67.9th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+2.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **80 days** median, +1.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 67.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 80th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked in the top tier at the 96th percentile with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.01. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a thriving job market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has seen employment growth of 1.16% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of +0.667% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth accompanied by increasing hours worked, suggesting a strong and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.59 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the top tier at the 80th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos stands at 3.90%, ranking in the near median at the 46th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For businesses trying to hire in this market, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that while it may not be overly challenging to find candidates, there is still competition for top talent.

Wage Growth

Year-over-year wage growth in the Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area is +5.08%, placing it above average at the 70th percentile. This rate of wage growth is relatively fast, implying rising labor costs for employers but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive in this market.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 96th, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is considered highly affordable relative to its peers, particularly given its PSF of $228/sqft which has decreased by 8.4% year-over-year compared to hourly earnings of $37.93. This affordability advantage is a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can recruit and retain workers without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has grown by 0.64% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city's hiring capacity is likely to remain robust, supporting business expansion and recruitment efforts.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +2.50%, indicating a moderate expansion of housing supply. Although this growth is near the median at the 50th percentile, it suggests that the city is making some progress in addressing potential housing shortages and affordability concerns, which is beneficial for future workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

Homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos currently sit on the market for a median of 80 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.3%. This relatively slow market, ranked in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, means that relocating workers may find it more accessible to purchase or rent a home, as the market is not overly competitive.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is significant, with a composite score ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city particularly well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable living costs, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for corporate investment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the potential for housing supply to tighten if building permit growth does not keep pace with labor force expansion, which could erode the city's affordability advantage over time.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A-

GOOD

67.2th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.5%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-22.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **N/A** median, N/A YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 67.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier ranking of 96th percentile, and its relatively low unemployment rate of 3.70%, ranking at the 84th percentile. The combination of these metrics signals a city with genuine demand expansion and a tight labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is +1.54% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +1.361% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing, indicating a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.82 further reinforces this, ranking at the 96th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.70%, which is relatively low and ranks at the 84th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it more challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is +4.22%, which is above average and ranks at the 62nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. Meanwhile, workers will benefit from increased purchasing power, supporting local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a cost of living score ranking at the 78th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $217/sqft to $38.91/hr, or 5.58. The fact that PSF is falling -1.4% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage will help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is shrinking at a rate of -1.49% year-over-year, ranking at the 40th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to compensate for this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has decreased by -22.75% year-over-year, ranking at the 12th percentile. This sharp decline in permits signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could negatively impact the city's ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Unfortunately, the current median days on market is not available for Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia. However, given the city's strong labor market and low unemployment, a rising days on market would likely indicate a healthy normalization of the housing market. Conversely, a falling days on market would suggest a highly competitive market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is significant, ranking at the 86th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may be less ideal for industries with predominantly industrial or logistics-based workforces.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively low unemployment rate, and a moderate wage growth rate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply and the tightening housing market, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for talent in the future.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A-

GOOD

67.1th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **2.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.3%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-26.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **35 days** median, -2.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 67.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 86th percentile, and its extremely low unemployment rate of 2.70%, ranking it at the 98th percentile. The combination of these two metrics suggests a highly competitive job market with genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.88% year-over-year, accompanied by a +0.025% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a thriving economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.96 further reinforces this trend, ranking it at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, which is extremely low and ranks it at the 98th percentile. This suggests a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +5.30%, which is above average and ranks it at the 74th percentile. This indicates that wages are rising at a moderate to fast pace, which may lead to increased labor costs for employers. However, it also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power and increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local businesses.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living ratio of $250/sqft to $40.19/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.22, which ranks it at the 24th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by 3.7% year-over-year further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate ranking it at the 96th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of

potential employees to hire from. This trend is likely to continue, making it easier for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has decreased by -26.73% year-over-year, which is a significant decline ranking it at the 10th percentile. This suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to increased competition for available housing and upward pressure on prices. This trend may negatively impact future affordability and workforce accommodation in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is currently 35 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.8%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, although the decrease in days on market suggests that it may be slowing down slightly. For workers relocating to this city, the market may still be competitive, but the slight slowdown could make it more accessible.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a professional and office worker share of 1.90, ranking it at the 26th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for industries that are less dependent on specialized office skills.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a highly competitive job market with strong labor demand and a growing workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract talent, and the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A-

GOOD

67.0th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.6%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+8.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-1.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **44 days** median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 67.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.60% and strong wage growth of +8.11% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest that Cincinnati is an attractive location for businesses seeking a skilled workforce, but may pose challenges for hiring and talent retention.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +0.31% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from trend by +0.000%, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.73, which ranks below average in the 32nd percentile. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are not significantly above trend despite job growth. However, the low labor demand score suggests that the city's job market may not be as robust as its low unemployment rate would imply.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.60%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Cincinnati may face significant challenges in finding available workers, and may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers in Cincinnati have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +8.11% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees are seeing significant increases in their earnings. However, it may pose challenges for businesses seeking to control labor costs, as they may need to adjust their pricing or operating models to accommodate rising wages.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living score that ranks in the top tier at the 94th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $190/sqft to $36.31/hr, or 5.23. The city's PSF is also falling by -1.0% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to wages. This means that Cincinnati has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a high quality of life without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is shrinking by -1.35% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This contraction in labor supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find available workers to fill open positions. The

shrinking labor force also suggests that Cincinnati's workforce may not be as dynamic or adaptable as other cities.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Cincinnati are falling by -1.83% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply may be tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the city. The falling permits also signal that developer confidence may be waning, which could have implications for the city's long-term economic growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cincinnati is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.8%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for longer, making it a more accessible and less competitive market for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market also suggests that the city's housing market may be normalizing, with less pressure on prices and more opportunities for buyers.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share is 2.30, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderate-sized talent pool of specialized workers, making it suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may not be as well-suited for businesses requiring a large pool of industrial or logistics workers.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and a high quality of life, making it an attractive location for companies seeking a skilled workforce. However, the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Cincinnati as a potential business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

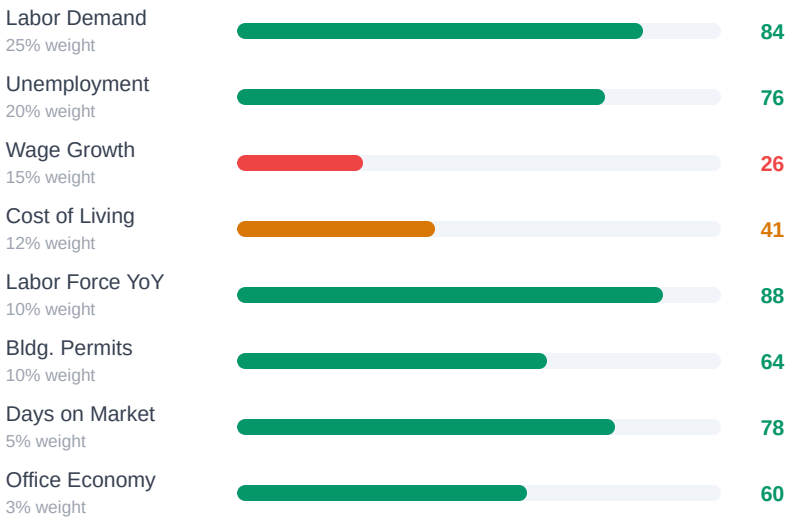
A-

GOOD

65.9th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+16.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **49 days** median, +8.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 65.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 84th percentile, and its above-average labor force growth rate of 1.23% YoY. The combination of these metrics signals a city with genuine demand expansion and a growing workforce.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 0.83% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating 1.300% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. The labor demand composite score of 6.76 further supports this conclusion, indicating a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 4.40%, ranking in the 76th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that while it may be slightly more challenging to find talent, it is still possible to attract workers without excessive wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 2.14%, which is below average, ranking in the 26th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly.

Cost of Living

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a cost of living score ranking in the 41st percentile, with a PSF of $228/sqft and average hourly earnings of $32.59/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.00. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither particularly expensive nor cheap. The fact that PSF is falling by 0.9% YoY is a positive sign for affordability, making it easier for businesses to attract talent without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is growing at a rate of 1.23% YoY, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 88th percentile. This expanding labor force supply implies that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is increasing by 16.37% YoY, which is above average, ranking in the 64th percentile. This expansion of housing supply signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, making it easier for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 49 days, with a YoY increase of 8.9%, ranking in the 78th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market, but still accessible for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is above average, ranking in the 60th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy companies.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with growing demand and an expanding workforce, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and grow. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the moderate wage growth rate, which may lead to rising labor costs over time, potentially impacting business profitability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #10 OF 50

Kansas City

Kansas City

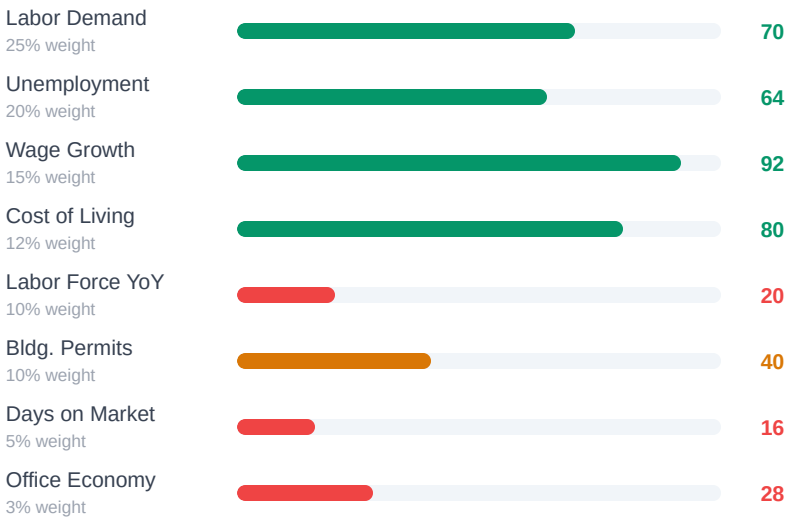
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

61.3th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.3%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-3.3%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **50 days** median, -2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 61.3th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.35%, and its labor demand composite score of 5.99, which indicates genuine demand expansion. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate is 0.73% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is 0.665%, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.99 further supports this conclusion, ranking the city in the 70th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Kansas City is 3.90%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. With an unemployment rate ranking in the 64th percentile, the city's labor market has some slack, but not much.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Kansas City is strong, with a year-over-year increase of 7.35%, ranking in the 92nd percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a skilled and productive workforce.

Cost of Living

Kansas City has a cost of living score ranking it in the 80th percentile, indicating that it is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The city's price-to-salary ratio is $195/sqft vs $36.37/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.36. This affordability makes it an attractive location for talent, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring excessive wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is shrinking, with a year-over-year growth rate of -2.09%, ranking in the 20th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. This could lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Kansas City has decreased by 3.34% year-over-year, ranking in the 40th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which could lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Kansas City is 50 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.0%, ranking in the 16th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. However, this also suggests a strong demand for housing and a vibrant local economy.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is relatively low, ranking in the 28th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in specialized roles, making it less suited for businesses that require a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses with industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers a strong and growing economy with increasing labor costs, making it an attractive location for businesses that can adapt to a competitive labor market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which could lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages, making it essential to factor this into their location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

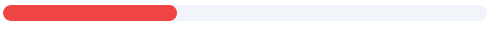
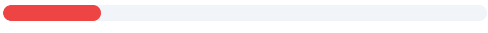
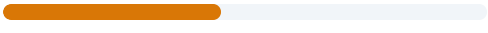
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

61.2th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand (25% weight)		82
Unemployment (20% weight)		36
Wage Growth (15% weight)		54
Cost of Living (12% weight)		88
Labor Force YoY (10% weight)		78
Bldg. Permits (10% weight)		20
Days on Market (5% weight)		45
Office Economy (3% weight)		94

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+4.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.0%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.6%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-15.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
62 days
median, -1.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 61.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 88th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.00% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.903% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.00% employment growth rate and a 0.903% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area. This indicates that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked also increasing, suggesting a strong and vibrant labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.60 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington stands at 4.40%, which ranks below average at the 36th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent, and businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract the best candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.03%, which is near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate. At the same time, workers are seeing their purchasing power rise, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $198/sqft to $38.10/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 2.5% in PSF, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is highly affordable, ranking at the 88th percentile. This makes the city an attractive location for talent, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a rate of 0.62% year-over-year, which is above average at the 78th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to find and hire talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -15.89%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and potential constraints on workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 62 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.6%. This relatively fast market suggests that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. However, the slight decrease in days on market may indicate a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked at the 94th percentile, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a deep and talented pool of knowledge-economy workers. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool, making it an attractive location for a wide range of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

60.5th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+6.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.5%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-2.3%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **46 days** median, +17.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 60.5th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.90% and high wage growth of +5.99% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. The combination of these metrics suggests a competitive environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.47% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.175% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.64, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a slowdown in job growth. The negative hours deviation suggests that remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles, characteristic of a survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 3.90%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and wage pressure may be higher. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +5.99%, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees have more disposable income to spend on goods and services. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses, as rising labor costs can erode profit margins.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile, with a PSF of $215/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.96/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.66. The city's PSF is falling by -2.7% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to peers. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can enjoy a relatively low cost of living without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of -0.45% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This negative growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in

the long term. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is decreasing by -2.34% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of +17.9%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to the city, this may be a competitive advantage, as they have more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has an office economy score ranking below average at the 36th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers of 2.14. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for tech, finance, and consulting businesses, but may be more suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, rising wages, and a relatively low cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor force supply, which may pose challenges for hiring and workforce development in the long term. As a result, businesses should carefully consider their talent attraction and retention strategies when deciding to locate in this city.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #13 OF 50

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

60.2th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	72
Unemployment	20% weight	24
Wage Growth	15% weight	90
Cost of Living	12% weight	71
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	22
Days on Market	5% weight	61
Office Economy	3% weight	90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+6.1%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.4%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-15.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
77 days
median, -2.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 60.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 72nd percentile, and its top-tier wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.12%. These metrics signal a city with a robust job market and rising earnings.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 0.80% year-over-year and a deviation of weekly hours 0.783% above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing, indicating a strong and growing labor market. This suggests that businesses can expect to find a talented and available workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford stands at 4.60%, which ranks in the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire, but it also implies weaker local consumer demand. For a business trying to hire, this market offers a relatively accessible pool of potential employees.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.12%, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking it in the 90th percentile. This rapid increase in wages implies rising labor costs for employers but also means that workers have strong purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score ranking it in the 71st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $222/sqft to $34.05/hr, or 6.52. Given that the PSF is falling by 3.1% year-over-year, this city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability is a talent attraction advantage, as businesses can attract workers without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 0.38% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is likely to remain strong, as more workers are entering or remaining in the labor market.

Building Permits

The city has seen a year-over-year decrease in residential building permits of 15.65%, ranking it in the 22nd percentile. This decline signals that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend may pose a risk to businesses relying on a readily available and affordable housing supply for their employees.

Days on Market

Homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford are currently sitting on the market for a median of 77 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.5%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 61st percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which can be competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, this also indicates a healthy and active real estate market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking it in the 90th percentile, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This city is well-suited for knowledge-economy businesses but may be less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

In conclusion, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and top-tier wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a talented and relatively affordable workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

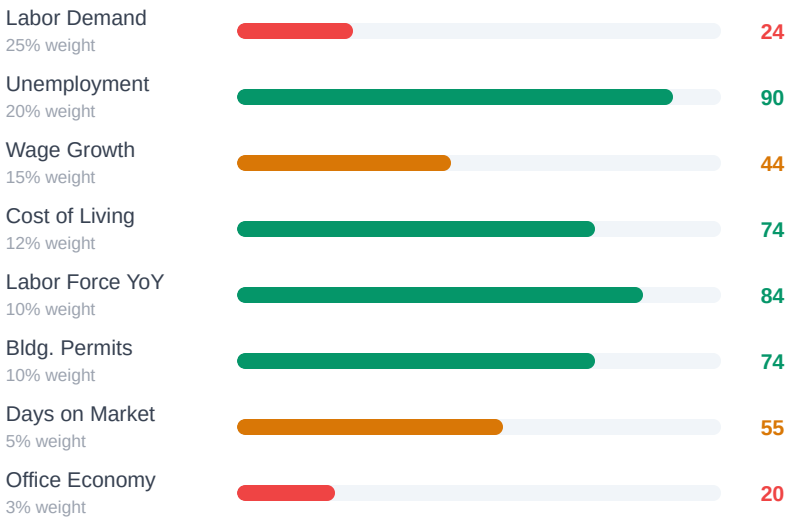
B

AVERAGE

58.6th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.3%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+24.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **54 days** median, +3.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B, ranking 58.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.90% and a cost of living score that indicates relative affordability. The city's labor demand and office economy metrics, however, suggest a more mixed economic character, with employment growth and professional sector job share being below average. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 4.06 and an office/professional worker share percentile rank of 20th pct are key defining metrics.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.05% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.173% from its own trend, signaling a scenario where hours are slightly above trend during a period of job losses, which may indicate a survivor squeeze. This suggests that while there might be some demand for labor, it's not translating into significant job additions. The labor demand composite score of 4.06, ranking in the 24th percentile, further reinforces this interpretation of below-average labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.90%, placing it in the top tier with a 90th percentile rank, indicating a very tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the limited availability of workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. In practical terms, a company looking to expand or establish operations in Pittsburgh may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Pittsburgh is +3.33% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate, while workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the pace of wage growth is not exceptionally high, which might influence business decisions regarding labor costs and investment in the area.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living, with a PSF of $170/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.44, results in a ratio of 5.08, and the PSF is decreasing by -1.2% year-over-year, contributing to an above-average affordability score of 74th percentile. This relative affordability is a significant advantage for talent attraction, as it means that workers can maintain a good standard of living without necessitating wage premiums from employers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of +1.07% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply is a positive indicator for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential workers. However, the rate of growth, while positive, is not exceptionally high, which may still pose some challenges in finding specific skill sets.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Pittsburgh are increasing by +24.71% year-over-year, ranking in the 74th percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals that housing supply is expected to expand, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This trend is favorable for businesses considering relocation or expansion, as it indicates a future supply of housing that can support their workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Pittsburgh is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.9%. This places the city near the median in terms of housing market speed, suggesting a relatively balanced market that is neither too competitive nor too slow. For workers relocating to Pittsburgh, this indicates a moderately accessible housing market, though the slight increase in days on market may signal a minor normalization in the market's pace.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office sector job share ranks in the 20th percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these areas compared to other cities. This suggests that Pittsburgh is less suited for businesses heavily reliant on tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations that require a dense network of professional services. However, it may be more accommodating to industries with different workforce requirements.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers a unique blend of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and relative affordability, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses, especially those that can leverage its specific economic strengths. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the below-average labor demand and the relatively shallow professional talent pool, which could pose challenges for businesses requiring rapid expansion or highly specialized labor forces.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

57.6th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	66
Unemployment	20% weight	28
Wage Growth	15% weight	76
Cost of Living	12% weight	45
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	58
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	72
Days on Market	5% weight	69
Office Economy	3% weight	74

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.8%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+5.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.9%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.5%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+23.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
51 days
median, +8.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 57.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven significantly by its above-average labor demand and strong wage growth, at 66th and 76th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is most defined by its employment growth rate of 0.88% year-over-year and its weekly hours deviation of 0.406% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. With a wage growth rate of 5.44% year-over-year, this city presents a unique blend of labor market dynamics.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 0.88% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.406% above its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.94 places the city in the 66th percentile, further reinforcing the notion of a thriving labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue stands at 4.80%, which ranks in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The low unemployment rate suggests that the city's labor market has less slack, making it more competitive for employers to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.44%, placing it in the 76th percentile, which signifies fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong purchasing power for workers. As wages continue to grow at this pace, businesses should anticipate higher labor costs, while workers can expect increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $427/sqft to $48.08/hr, resulting in a ratio of 8.88, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue ranks in the 45th percentile for affordability. This near-median ranking suggests that the city is neither exceptionally affordable nor overly expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.5% year-over-year relative to wages is a key driver of its affordability score, making it more attractive for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has contracted by 0.54% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses should be aware that the diminishing labor force could exacerbate the challenges of finding suitable talent in the area.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 23.71% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This increase suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is expected to improve, which could lead to better affordability and easier accommodation for the workforce. The rising permits indicate a positive outlook for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

Homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue currently sit on the market for a median of 51 days, with an 8.5% year-over-year increase, placing it in the 69th percentile. This increase in days on market, combined with the absolute level, suggests a normalization of the housing market, making it slightly more accessible for relocating workers. However, the market remains relatively competitive, and workers may still face challenges in finding and securing housing.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 74th percentile for its share of office and professional workers. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on a knowledgeable and skilled workforce. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles, which require different skill sets.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and the associated upward pressure on wages, which could increase labor costs and require strategic hiring and retention practices to attract and keep top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #16 OF 50

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

54.8th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.3%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-10.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **76 days** median, -3.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 54.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.71, and its top-tier cost of living, with a percentile rank of 84th. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, while the cost of living is influenced by a PSF to earnings ratio of $232/sqft to $37.29/hr, which is decreasing by 6.1% YoY.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is +0.92% YoY, and the weekly hours deviation from the 12-month baseline is +0.120%. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.71 is above average, ranking at the 60th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.70%, which is relatively high, ranking at the 16th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is +5.13%, which is above average, ranking at the 72nd percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may face higher labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living percentile rank of 84th, indicating that it is more affordable than most peer cities. The PSF to earnings ratio of $232/sqft to $37.29/hr is decreasing by 6.1% YoY, making the city more attractive to talent without requiring wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a significant draw for businesses looking to attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of +0.34% YoY, which is above average, ranking at the 70th percentile. This expansion of the labor force supply implies that hiring capacity is increasing, making it easier for businesses to find workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is -10.10%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 76 days, with a YoY decrease of -3.8%. This relatively fast market, with a percentile rank of 65th, implies that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 82nd. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #17 OF 50

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

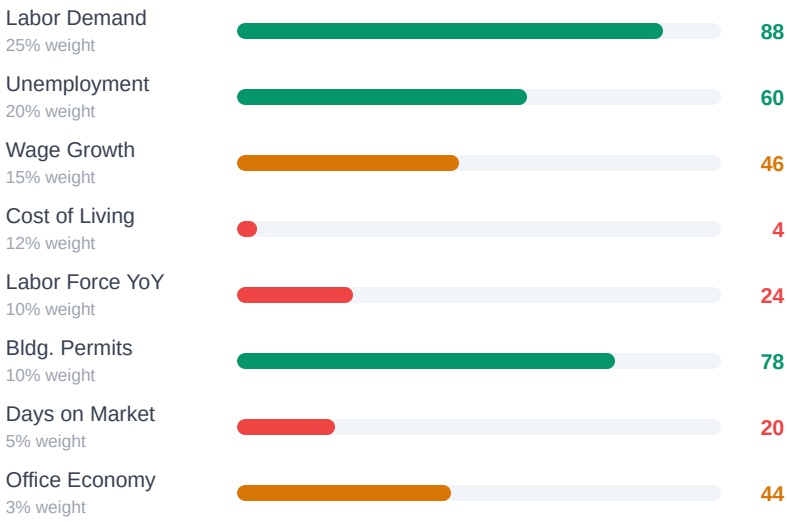
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

53.9th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+26.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **55 days** median, -3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 53.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 88th percentile, and its high cost of living, ranking at the 4th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.83% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.151% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has a labor demand composite score of 7.01, ranking at the 88th percentile, driven by a 1.83% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.151% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 4.80%, ranking at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. As a result, businesses may experience upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 3.39%, ranking at the 46th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a moderate pace, and workers have relatively stable purchasing power. While this may not be ideal for businesses looking to keep labor costs low, it is a positive sign for workers and the local economy.

Cost of Living

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has a cost of living ratio of $647/sqft to $41.54/hr, with a percentile rank of 4, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The fact that the PSF is falling by 2.7% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the city's overall affordability score is still low. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, as the high cost of living may be a deterrent for some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is contracting at a rate of -1.91% year-over-year, ranking at the 24th percentile. This indicates that the labor pool is shrinking, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business

expansion. Businesses may need to be more competitive in their hiring practices and offer attractive compensation packages to attract workers from a shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has seen a 26.84% year-over-year increase in building permits, ranking at the 78th percentile. This indicates that housing supply is expanding, which may help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to attract and retain workers, as a more affordable and available housing stock can be a major draw.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 55 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 3.5%, ranking at the 20th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and purchase homes. Businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to help workers navigate this competitive market.

Office Economy

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an office economy percentile rank of 44, indicating a relatively deep professional talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The city's professional talent pool is a major asset for businesses looking to establish or expand operations in these sectors.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and an expanding housing supply, but also presents challenges such as a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and a high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

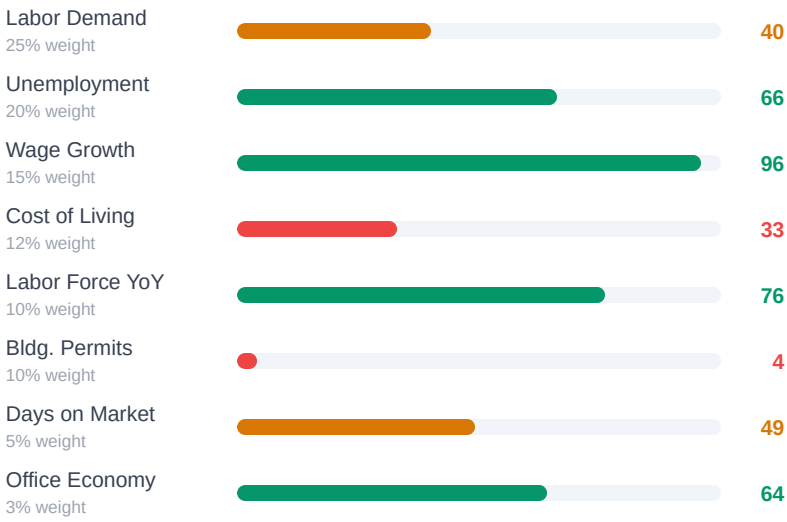
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

53.9th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-34.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **85 days** median, -4.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 53.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.68% year-over-year and its low cost of living percentile rank of 33, indicating a relatively expensive market. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with strong labor cost pressures but limited affordability advantages.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.35% year-over-year, accompanied by a 0.285% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing, indicating a growing need for labor. However, the near-median percentile rank of 40 suggests that this growth is not exceptionally strong compared to other metros.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.70%, ranking at the 66th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The practical implication is that companies may experience upward pressure on wages and potentially longer recruitment times.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.68%, placing it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising rapidly, which can be beneficial for worker purchasing power but may strain business budgets. The high wage growth indicates a strong demand for labor, which can drive economic activity but also increases the cost of doing business.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 33, Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is considered relatively expensive, especially given its PSF to earnings ratio of $355/sqft to $35.24/hr, equating to 10.07. Although the PSF is falling by 0.8% year-over-year, the city's affordability is still below average. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging, as the high cost of living could offset the appeal of the area's other economic advantages.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of 0.39% year-over-year, ranking at the 76th percentile. This positive growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a larger pool of potential employees. The growing labor force can support business expansion and reduce the risk of labor shortages.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -34.10%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This significant decline signals that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The sharp decrease in building permits is a concern for businesses reliant on a readily available and affordable housing stock for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.5%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, although the near-median percentile rank of 49 suggests it is not exceptionally competitive. For workers relocating to this city, the market is somewhat accessible, but the trend towards faster sales could indicate rising demand and potentially less favorable conditions for buyers in the future.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share percentile rank of 64, Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. However, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses seeking specialized knowledge workers.

In conclusion, Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a tightening labor market, suggesting strong economic activity but also potential challenges in hiring and labor costs. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living and the sharp decline in building permits, which could exacerbate affordability issues and limit the availability of housing for a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

Columbus

Columbus

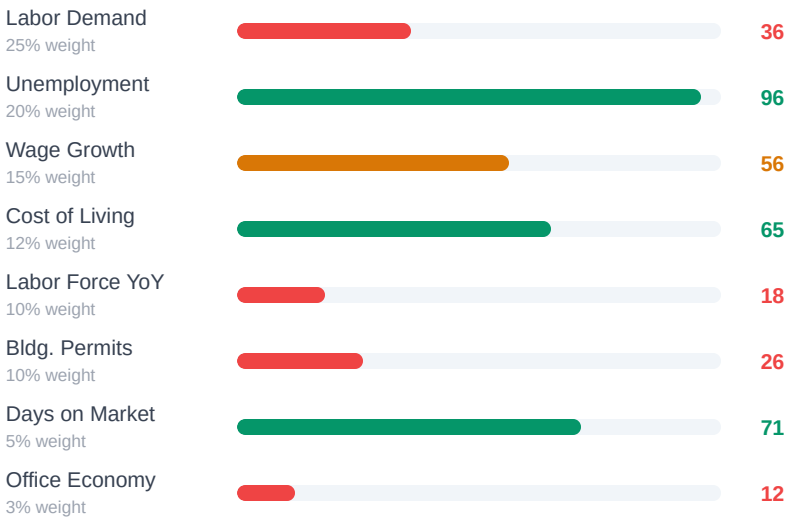
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

52.8th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-15.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **48 days** median, +6.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 52.8th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.30% and a labor demand composite score of 4.88, which ranks below average at the 36th percentile. The city's economic character is most defined by its tight labor market and moderate wage growth. Specifically, the combination of a +0.06% employment growth rate and +0.492% weekly hours deviation signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a slow one.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is +0.06% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.492% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. However, the below-average labor demand composite score suggests that this expansion is not particularly strong.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 3.30%, ranking at the 96th percentile, which means the market is extremely tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate exerts upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Columbus is +4.15% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in Columbus are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can benefit local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living score that ranks at the 65th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $205/sqft to $34.84/hr, or 5.88. This indicates that the city is slightly above average in terms of affordability. However, the fact that the PSF is not falling year-over-year means that affordability is not improving. Still, the relatively high affordability score suggests that Columbus may have a talent attraction advantage without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, ranking at the 18th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to compensate for this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Columbus is decreasing by -14.98% year-over-year, ranking at the 26th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Columbus is currently 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.7%, ranking at the 71st percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it a more accessible market for relocating workers. However, this trend may also indicate a normalization of the market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Columbus has a professional and office worker share that ranks at the 12th percentile, with a composite score of 0.82. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in terms of professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent. Instead, Columbus may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Columbus offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and moderate wage growth, but also poses challenges such as a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth, which may require businesses to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

51.8th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+15.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **60 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 51.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.40% ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is -0.46% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.595% above the city's own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.06 is in the bottom tier, indicating payrolls are contracting.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.40%, which is in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This signals a tight market with little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to wage pressure. For a business trying to hire in this city, the tight labor market implies a competitive environment where attracting and retaining talent may be challenging.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Atlanta is +3.11%, which is below average at the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means workers have somewhat stronger purchasing power. However, the pace of wage growth is not exceptionally high, suggesting a relatively stable cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

Atlanta has a cost of living score that ranks in the above-average tier at the 76th percentile, with a PSF of $194/sqft that is decreasing by 0.5% year-over-year, compared to hourly earnings of $37.62. This means the city is relatively more affordable than its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +1.18% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Atlanta is increasing by +15.21% year-over-year, ranking in the above-average tier at the 62nd percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in building permits is a positive indicator for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Atlanta is 60 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking in the below-average tier at the 35th percentile. This suggests a relatively fast-paced market that may be competitive for relocating workers, potentially making it tougher for them to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Atlanta ranks in the below-average tier at the 32nd percentile. This indicates a less deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, suggesting the city might be more suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics. The city's economy is not as heavily weighted towards professional services as some of its peers.

In conclusion, Atlanta offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding labor force, but it also presents challenges such as a tight labor market and moderate wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the city's low labor demand, which could signal a challenging environment for hiring and expansion, potentially requiring strategic planning to attract and retain talent in a competitive market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #21 OF 50

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

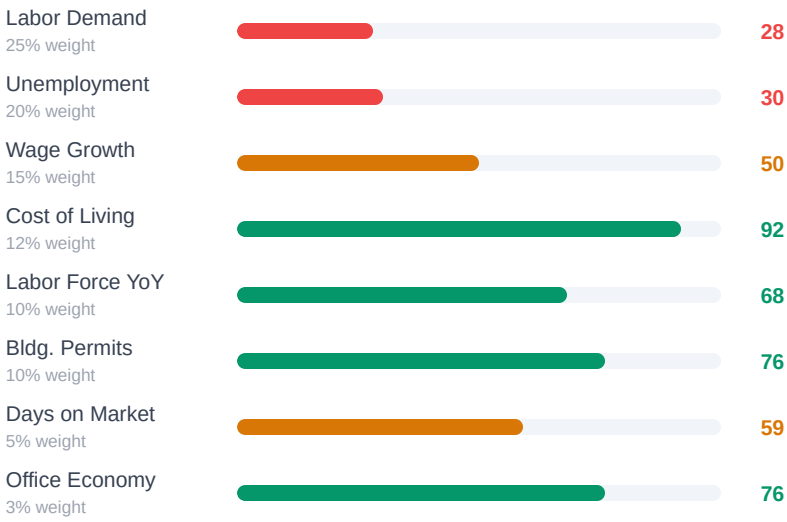
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

51.2th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+26.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **71 days** median, -2.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 51.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.36, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 92nd percentile. The cost of living is particularly notable, with a price per square foot of $170 and average hourly earnings of $33.17, resulting in a ratio of 5.13.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 0.51% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.651% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend during a period of modest job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.36 is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.50%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, although not extremely so. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests some competition for talent, but not an overly challenging hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 3.73%, which is near the median, ranking at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, while worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. The wage growth rate is neither exceptionally fast nor stagnant, providing a relatively stable environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a highly affordable cost of living, with a percentile rank of 92. The price per square foot is $170, and average hourly earnings are $33.17, resulting in a ratio of 5.13. This affordability is a significant advantage for talent attraction, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing to provide large premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of 0.23% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This expanding labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels is increasing by 25.98% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 76th percentile. This rapid growth in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 71 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.7%. This relatively fast market suggests that workers relocating to the city may face competition for housing, although the market is not extremely heated. The decreasing days on market indicates a strong demand for housing, which may pose challenges for relocating workers.

Office Economy

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 76. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-based workforces.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability, moderate wage growth, and an expanding labor force. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the below-average labor demand, which may limit the city's ability to support extremely rapid business growth or expansion. Despite this, the city's overall economic character and highly affordable cost of living make it an attractive location for businesses seeking a stable and competitive environment.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #22 OF 50

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

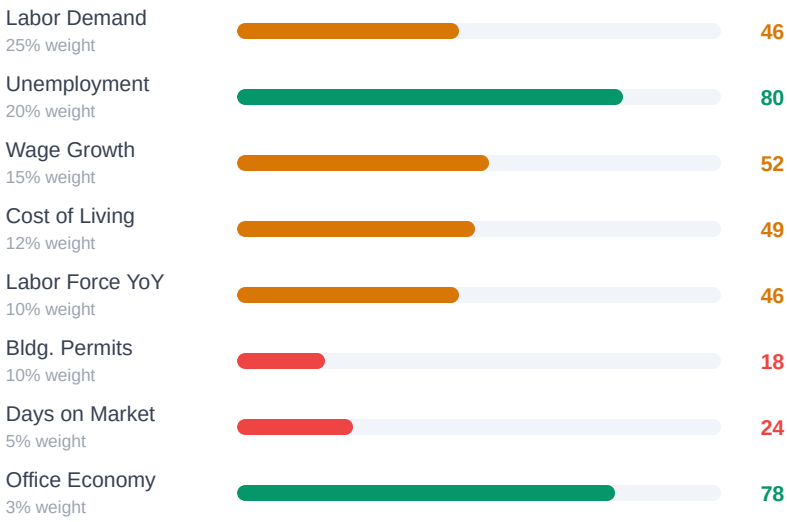
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

51.1th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.2%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.9%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.3%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-17.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **62 days** median, +5.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 51.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.26, indicating a mix of positive and neutral signals. The unemployment rate and labor demand metrics suggest a relatively tight labor market with moderate job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Nashville is +0.65% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.047% from its own trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, suggesting a moderate level of labor demand. The labor demand composite score of 5.26, ranking at the 46th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville is 3.20%, ranking at the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Nashville is +3.92%, ranking at the 52nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a moderate pace, and that workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. The moderate wage growth may help attract and retain workers, but may also increase costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

Nashville has a cost of living score ranking at the 49th percentile, with a PSF of $259/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.74/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.25. The city's cost of living is near the median, making it neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The relatively stable cost of living means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract workers, but may still face some challenges in talent attraction.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville is contracting at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction suggests that the supply of workers is decreasing, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. The declining labor force growth rate may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Nashville has decreased by -17.83% year-over-year, ranking at the 18th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in building permits suggests that the city's housing supply is not expanding to meet demand, which may lead to future affordability challenges and limitations on workforce accommodation. The decrease in building permits may exacerbate the city's existing housing affordability issues.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Nashville is 62 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.1%. This increase in days on market suggests that the housing market is normalizing, but may still be relatively competitive for relocating workers. The rising days on market may indicate a slight easing of the housing market, but workers may still face challenges in finding affordable housing.

Office Economy

Nashville has an office economy score ranking at the 78th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. The city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The strong office economy suggests that businesses requiring specialized knowledge workers may find Nashville an attractive location.

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate job growth and a deep talent pool in professional sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth and create challenges for workforce accommodation and affordability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

Cleveland

Cleveland

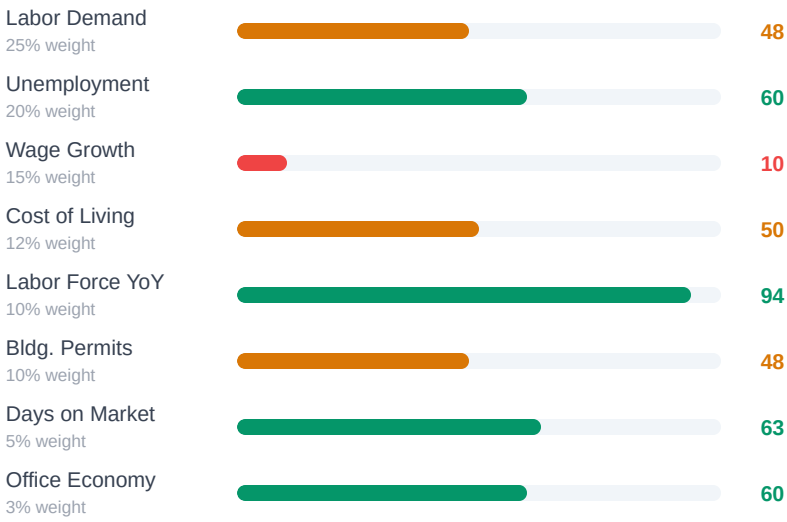
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

50.7th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.9%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-0.6%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **55 days** median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 50.7th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand and low wage growth, with a labor demand composite score of 5.27 and wage growth of +0.88% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with employment growth and hours worked near the national median, but wage pressures lagging behind.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% year-over-year, combined with a +0.170% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month trend. This signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.27, ranking near the median at 48th percentile, indicates a moderate level of job market activity.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, with some slack but generally favorable conditions for workers. For a business trying to hire in Cleveland, this means that hiring may be more challenging and wage pressure could be higher due to the lower unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cleveland is +0.88% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may face less pressure to increase wages, but workers may have limited disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living is near the median, with a percentile rank of 50th, and a price-to-salary ratio of $143/sqft to $34.26/hr, or 4.17. However, the PSF has increased by 13.5% year-over-year, indicating a less affordable environment. This suggests that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums to offset the rising cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the city. The growing labor force provides a favorable environment for recruitment and talent acquisition.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cleveland has decreased by -0.61% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which could lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.8%, ranking above average at the 63rd percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city as they have more time to find a home. However, this also suggests that the housing market may be normalizing after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

Cleveland's professional and office worker share is 2.86, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with limited office-based roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers a mixed economic environment with a growing labor force and a relatively tight labor market, but also stagnant wage growth and a rising cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering Cleveland as a location is the potential for future affordability concerns and housing market tightening, which could impact their ability to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

50.4th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.8%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-2.0%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-3.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+27.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **43 days** median, +13.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 50.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.85%. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -1.96% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.606% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or hire new workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 3.80%, which ranks in the 78th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring new workers, as the pool of available labor is relatively small. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.85%, which is in the top tier of US metros. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising quickly, but it also means that workers have strong purchasing power. This could be beneficial for businesses that rely on a highly skilled and highly paid workforce.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score that ranks in the 67th percentile, with a PSF of $301/sqft and average hourly earnings of $45.93/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.55. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage for businesses. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year also contributes to the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -3.61% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier of US metros. This decline in labor force supply suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding new workers, as the pool of available labor is shrinking. This could be a structural headwind for hiring and expansion plans.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by 27.36% year-over-year, which is in the top tier of US metros. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for workers in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.2%, ranking in the 94th percentile. This suggests a relatively slow market, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find a home. However, this could also indicate a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria ranks in the 32nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool compared to other US metros. This suggests that the city may be less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office talent, such as tech or finance companies.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and relatively low cost of living, but it also poses significant challenges, particularly in terms of labor demand and labor force growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the declining labor force supply, which could limit hiring and expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

C+

FAIR

49.7th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	56
Unemployment	20% weight	42
Wage Growth	15% weight	84
Cost of Living	12% weight	16
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	16
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	98
Days on Market	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	46

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+5.8%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-2.3%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+118.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
37 days
median, -9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking at the 49.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.78%, and its extremely competitive housing market, with a median days on market of 37 days and a year-over-year decrease of 9.8%. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.56% and a weekly hours deviation of 0.469% above its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.55. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend. However, the relatively modest employment growth rate suggests that this demand expansion is not overly robust.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 4.60%, ranking at the 42nd percentile, indicating a near median level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, but is not overly loose, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication is that businesses may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 5.78%, ranking at the 84th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This suggests that employer labor costs are rising rapidly, while worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a highly productive and skilled workforce.

Cost of Living

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has a cost of living ratio of $627/sqft to $50.39/hr, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.3% in PSF, ranking at the 16th percentile. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The low affordability score is a significant constraint for businesses looking to relocate or expand in this area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is contracting at a rate of -2.31% year-over-year, ranking at the 16th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has seen a year-over-year increase of 118.02% in building permits, ranking at the 98th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding rapidly, which may improve affordability and workforce accommodation in the future. However, the current housing market remains highly competitive, and it may take time for the increased supply to have a significant impact.

Days on Market

The median days on market in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 9.8%. This suggests that the housing market is highly competitive, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. The low days on market also indicates a seller's market, which may drive up housing costs and reduce affordability.

Office Economy

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has a professional and office worker share of 2.36, ranking at the 46th percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool, making it suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may not be as well-suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and productive workforce, with strong wage growth and a rapidly expanding housing supply. However, the city's extremely high cost of living and competitive housing market pose significant challenges for talent attraction and retention, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions. Ultimately, the biggest risk for businesses in this area is the potential for rising labor costs and reduced affordability, which could impact their bottom line and competitiveness.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

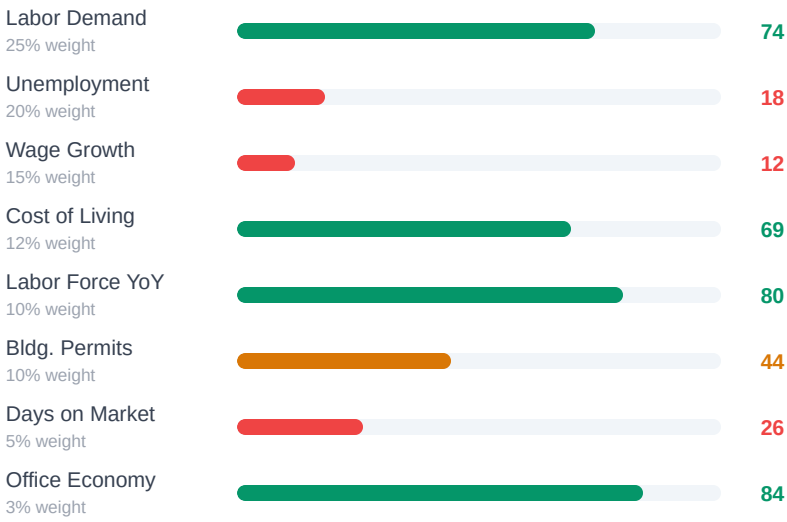
C+

FAIR

48.5th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **5.0%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-2.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **55 days** median, -1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking at the 48.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score ranking at the 74th percentile, and its high office economy share, ranking at the 84th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.30% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.091% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.30% and the weekly hours deviation of 0.091% above trend signal a genuine demand expansion in the labor market. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in job creation and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.21 further reinforces this notion, ranking at the 74th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 5.00%, which ranks at the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment compared to other metros. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing significant wage pressure. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 1.21%, ranking at the 12th percentile, which indicates stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost increases, but workers may not have strong disposable incomes to drive local demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $169/sqft to $36.92/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.7% in PSF, this city ranks at the 69th percentile in terms of affordability. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.64% year-over-year, ranking at the 80th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the labor pool is increasing, providing a favorable environment for hiring and business expansion. Businesses can expect a growing talent pool to draw from.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -2.18%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is not expanding as rapidly as in other metros, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This might signal a potential constraint on the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 55 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.8%. This relatively fast market, ranking at the 26th percentile, indicates that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, this also suggests a competitive and active real estate market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking at the 84th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy roles but may be less ideal for those with primarily industrial or logistics-dominant operations.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the potential for future affordability issues and housing supply constraints, driven by the decline in residential building permits, which could impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #27 OF 50

Birmingham

Birmingham

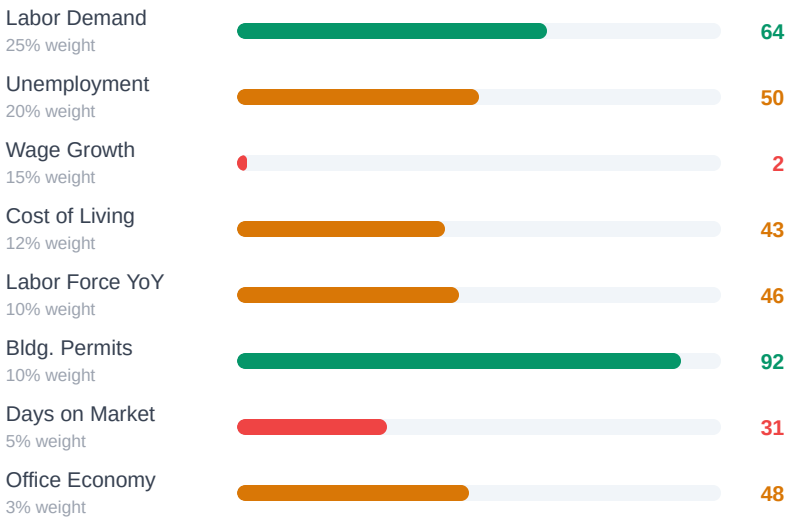
C+

FAIR

48.2th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.3%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+36.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **61 days** median, +5.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of C+ and a composite score ranking it 48.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its above-average labor demand and top-tier building permit growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.94, driven by a 0.92% employment growth rate and a 0.349% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the 36.73% year-over-year increase in building permits highlights a significant expansion in housing supply.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of 0.92% and weekly hours deviation of 0.349% above its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual. This combination signals a strong labor market where businesses can find workers with increasing hours, indicating a healthy economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.94 further reinforces this, ranking above average at the 64th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham stands at 3.40%, placing it near the median at the 50th percentile. This rate suggests a balanced labor market with neither too much slack nor too much tightness. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable hiring process without excessive wage pressure or undue difficulty in finding qualified candidates.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 0.03%, Birmingham experiences stagnant wage growth, ranking at the bottom tier of the 2nd percentile. This slow wage growth environment means labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. This could affect the attractiveness of the city for talent seeking better compensation.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of $157/sqft and average hourly earnings of $32.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.80, places it near the median at the 43rd percentile. The city is neither exceptionally affordable nor overly expensive compared to its peers. However, the 1.3% year-over-year decrease in PSF relative to wages slightly improves its affordability. This moderate cost of living means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but it does not provide a substantial talent attraction advantage either.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is contracting at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This negative growth rate, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile, suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is

decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding new talent as the labor force contracts.

Building Permits

The city experienced a 36.73% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, signaling a significant expansion in housing supply and ranking at the top tier of the 92nd percentile. This rapid growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is expected to increase, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Birmingham currently sit on the market for 61 days, with a 5.2% year-over-year increase. This increase in days on market, ranking below average at the 31st percentile, indicates a slightly slower market. For workers relocating to this city, the market is becoming more accessible, as homes are not selling as quickly as they were, providing more time for decision-making.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional and office worker share, with a composite score of 2.46, places it near the median at the 48th percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses requiring professional and office skills, such as tech, finance, and consulting. However, it is less suited for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a balanced labor market with genuine demand expansion and a rapidly expanding housing supply, which could attract businesses looking for a stable environment with improving affordability. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the stagnant wage growth, which could limit the city's appeal to top talent and affect local purchasing power, potentially impacting businesses reliant on a highly skilled and well-compensated workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

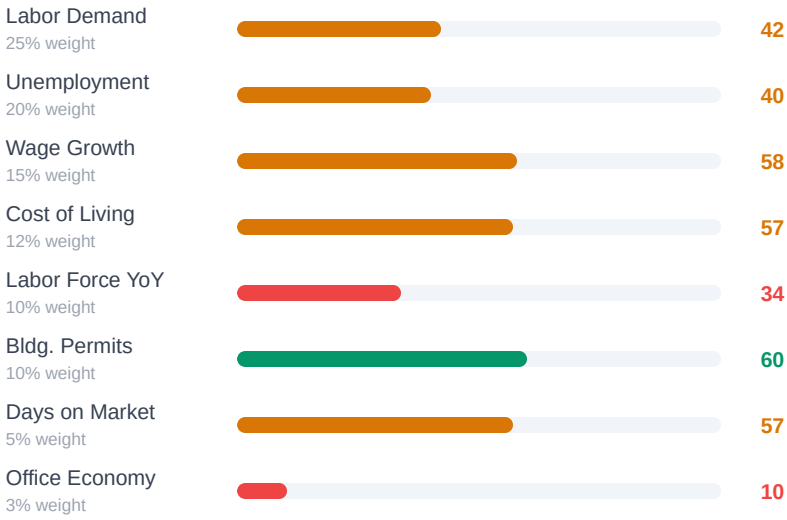
C+

FAIR

46.6th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+14.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **57 days** median, +9.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 46.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.17 and its below-average labor force growth rate of -1.65% YoY. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some indicators pointing to stability and others to potential challenges.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is +0.74% YoY, while weekly hours are -0.163% below trend. This combination signals a moderate expansion in jobs, but with hours worked slightly below the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating some degree of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.17 is near the median, suggesting a relatively stable but not particularly strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 3.90%, ranking near the median in terms of labor market tightness. This rate suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may not face extreme competition for talent, it still needs to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract the best candidates.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is +4.20% YoY, which is near the median in terms of pace. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing, which can support local consumer demand. The implication for employers is a need to balance wage increases with productivity gains to maintain profitability.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City has a cost of living score that ranks it near the median (57th percentile) in terms of affordability, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $171/sqft to $34.33/hr, or 4.98. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums. The city's affordability can help businesses attract and retain workers without incurring high labor costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -1.65% YoY, indicating a contracting labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions. The implication for

hiring capacity is that businesses may need to invest more in training and development or consider relocating workers from other areas.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Oklahoma City are increasing by +14.19% YoY, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the city is likely to see improvements in affordability and an easier time accommodating a growing workforce. The increase in housing supply can help mitigate potential workforce attraction and retention issues.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 57 days, with a YoY increase of +9.6%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be more accessible for relocating workers. However, the relatively fast pace of home sales still suggests a competitive market, and workers may face some challenges in finding and securing housing quickly.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share ranks in the bottom tier (10th percentile), indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs, like logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate labor market, which can be attractive for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's shrinking labor force, which poses challenges for hiring and workforce growth, and may require businesses to adapt their recruitment and retention strategies accordingly.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

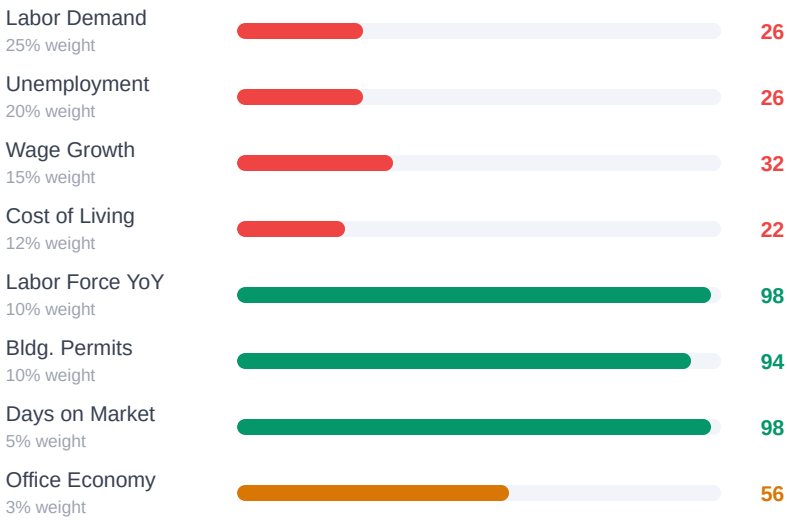
C+

FAIR

45.0th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.9%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+72.3%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **43 days** median, +19.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 45.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth of 2.87% YoY and its high building permits growth of 72.27% YoY, indicating a expanding workforce and housing supply. The labor demand composite score of 4.13, however, suggests a more nuanced economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.12% YoY and weekly hours deviation of -0.351% from the city's own trend signal a contraction in labor demand, indicating a lack of genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a slowdown in job creation, which may lead to a surplus of workers. The labor demand composite score of 4.13, ranking at the 26th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.90% is relatively low, ranking at the 26th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that it may be moderately challenging to find qualified candidates, and wage pressure may be present. However, the market is not extremely tight, allowing for some flexibility in hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 2.93% is moderate, ranking at the 32nd percentile. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. While this is not ideal for employers looking to minimize labor costs, it is beneficial for workers and the local economy.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Boston-Cambridge-Newton, with a PSF of $459/sqft and an earnings ratio of 10.02, ranks at the 22nd percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.0% YoY is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score suggests that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 2.87% YoY, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a large and increasing pool of potential employees. This is a significant advantage for businesses looking to hire in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 72.27%, ranking at the 94th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This growth suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence, which will lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 19.4%, ranking at the 98th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively low days on market still indicates a competitive market, and relocating workers may face some challenges in finding housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in the city is 2.70, ranking at the 56th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be ideal for industries that require a large amount of industrial or logistics workers.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers a unique combination of a strong and growing labor force, expanding housing supply, and a moderately deep professional talent pool. However, the city's relatively high cost of living and tight labor market may pose significant challenges for businesses looking to hire and attract talent without offering wage premiums, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating this location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #30 OF 50

Providence

Providence-Warwick

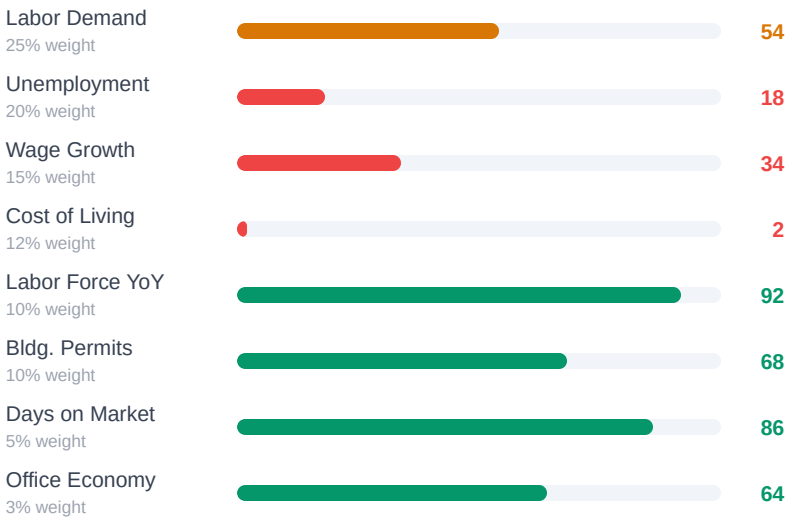
C+

FAIR

44.7th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.7%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+18.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **39 days** median, +8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high labor force growth rate of +1.69% YoY and its low unemployment rate of 4.30%, which signals a tight labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.47, near the median, also suggests a moderate level of job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.60% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.326% from the city's own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a moderate increase in labor demand. The labor demand composite score of 5.47, ranking near the median at 54th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, which means the labor market is tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer available workers, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. As a result, businesses may experience upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.09% is below average, ranking at 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may be beneficial for workers' purchasing power, it also means that employers may not face significant pressure to increase wages.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $360/sqft to $36.41/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.89, and a percentile rank of 2, the city is relatively expensive. The fact that PSF is increasing by +8.4% YoY further exacerbates the affordability issue. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.69% YoY, which is in the top tier at 92nd percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. As a result, businesses may find it easier to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +18.42%, ranking above average at 68th percentile. This increase in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.3%, ranking in the top tier at 86th percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it a more accessible market for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also indicate a normalization of the market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 2.92 and a percentile rank of 64, the city has a deep enough professional talent pool to support businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy talent, but less suited for those with primarily industrial or logistics-dominant workforces.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate labor demand, and expanding labor force supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

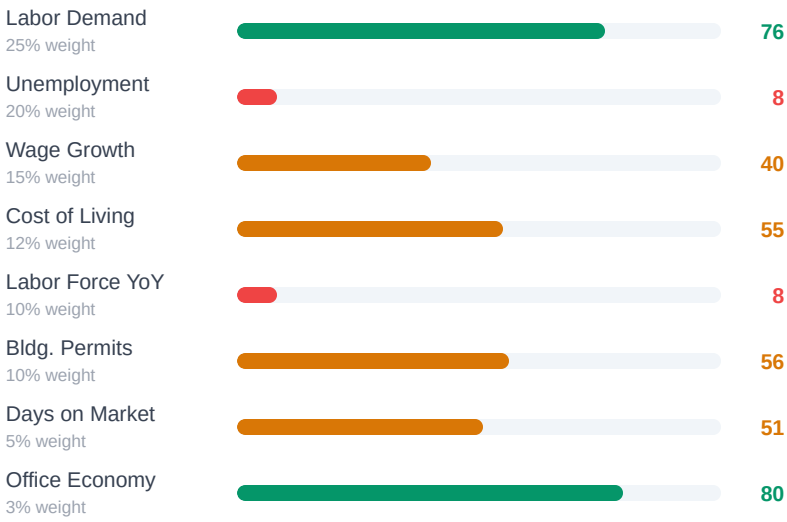
C+

FAIR

44.6th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.3%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+11.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **62 days** median, -4.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 76th percentile, and its labor force growth, which is in the bottom tier at 8th percentile with a -2.93% year-over-year change. The labor demand metrics, including employment growth and weekly hours, signal a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +0.91% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.771% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 is in the 76th percentile, further supporting this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +3.28%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and worker purchasing power is increasing. While this is not the fastest wage growth, it still indicates a relatively healthy labor market with some upward pressure on costs.

Cost of Living

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a cost of living percentile rank of 55th, indicating a near-median affordability level. The city's PSF (price per square foot) is $264, with a -1.9% year-over-year change, and the ratio of PSF to hourly earnings ($38.11) is 6.93. This affordability level means that the city can attract talent without necessarily requiring significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively manageable compared to other metros.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is shrinking at a rate of -2.93% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding the talent they need due to this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has increased by +10.99% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, as more housing units become available to meet demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 62 days, with a -4.6% year-over-year change. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market that is becoming slightly more competitive. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market may be somewhat challenging, but it is still accessible compared to hotter markets.

Office Economy

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile in terms of the share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on a knowledgeable and skilled workforce. However, it may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented needs.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a labor market with genuine demand expansion and moderate wage growth, but it also presents challenges due to a tight labor market and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the labor force contraction, which could limit the city's ability to support long-term business growth and expansion. Despite this, the city's affordability and deep professional talent pool make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

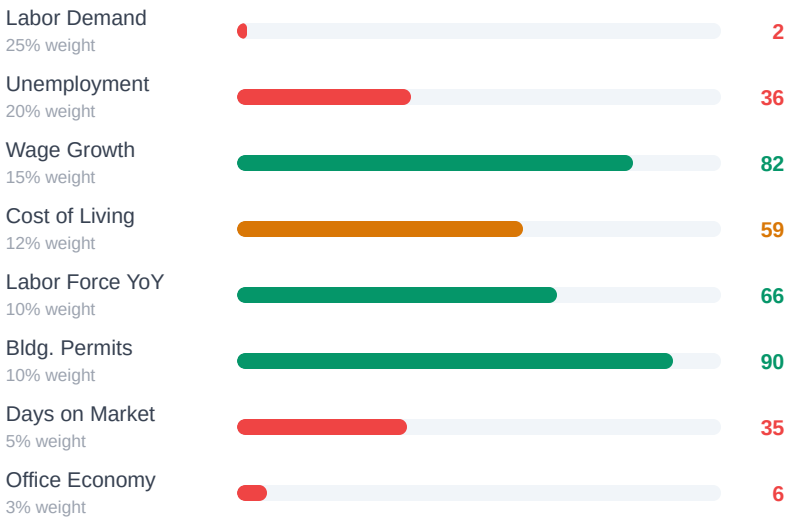
C+

FAIR

44.6th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-1.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+32.3%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **66 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.68%. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -1.52% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.368%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation. The positive deviation in weekly hours may suggest a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.90%, ranking it in the 36th percentile, which indicates a below-average labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. However, the unemployment rate is not extremely high, suggesting that the labor market is not overly loose.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.68%, ranking it in the top tier. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have strong purchasing power. Businesses may need to consider the increasing labor costs when deciding to locate in this city.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score ranking it in the 59th percentile, with a PSF of $303/sqft and average hourly earnings of $42.52/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.13. The city's PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year, which is a key driver of its relatively affordable score. This means that the city has a moderate affordability level, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of 0.05% year-over-year, ranking it above average. This slow but positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit at a slow pace. This implies that businesses may have a slightly increasing hiring capacity, but it may not be sufficient to meet rapid growth needs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is increasing by 32.26% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive signal for businesses considering relocation, as it may help attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 66 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 35th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not overheating, and workers may still find affordable options.

Office Economy

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a professional and office worker share ranking it in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that rely on specialized office workers.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and expanding housing supply, which can attract and retain talent. However, the city's weak labor demand and relatively high unemployment rate pose significant risks, and decision-makers should carefully consider these constraints when evaluating this location for their business. Overall, the city's complex economic environment requires careful analysis to determine whether its advantages outweigh its disadvantages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #33 OF 50

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

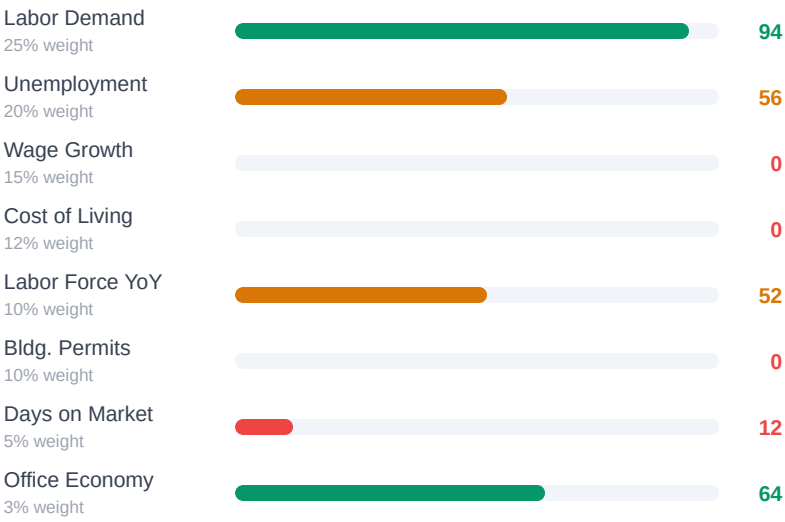
C

VERY POOR

42.4th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **-0.8%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-43.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **35 days** median, -2.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 42.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and deep office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.81, combining a 1.59% employment growth rate and a 1.289% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals genuine demand expansion. However, the city's poor wage growth and high cost of living are significant concerns.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a strong labor demand, with a 1.59% employment growth rate and a 1.289% weekly hours deviation above trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The labor demand composite score of 7.81 is in the top tier, at the 94th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 4.30%, which is near the median, ranking at the 56th percentile. This rate indicates that the labor market has some slack, but it is not overly loose, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The relatively low unemployment rate suggests that businesses may face some competition for talent, but it is not as intense as in cities with even lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is -0.78%, which is stagnant and ranks at the 0th percentile. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. The stagnant wage growth may make it easier for businesses to control labor costs, but it could also limit the attractiveness of the city to workers.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living that is expensive relative to peers, with a PSF of $827/sqft and an earnings ratio of 15.31, ranking at the 0th percentile. The fact that PSF is rising 0.5% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city even less affordable. This means that the city is at a disadvantage in terms of talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is contracting at a rate of -1.08% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking at the 52nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply indicates that the city's workforce is shrinking, which could create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. The contracting labor force may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has decreased by 43.67% year-over-year, which is a sharp decline ranking at the 0th percentile. This decrease in building permits signals that the city's housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and limit the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce. The decline in permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a growing and affordable housing stock to attract workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 35 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.8%, ranking at the 12th percentile. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The competitive housing market may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 2.92, ranking at the 64th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less suited for industries that require a large industrial or logistics workforce. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses that rely on specialized knowledge workers.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, but it also poses significant challenges, including a high cost of living and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the limited affordability and tightening housing supply, which could limit the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #34 OF 50

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C

VERY POOR

41.2th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand (25% weight)	14	
Unemployment (20% weight)	66	
Wage Growth (15% weight)	78	
Cost of Living (12% weight)	53	
Labor Force YoY (10% weight)	12	
Bldg. Permits (10% weight)	28	
Days on Market (5% weight)	35	
Office Economy (3% weight)	24	

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-10.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **44 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 41.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and labor force growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 3.36 and labor force growth rate of -2.61% YoY are the two metrics that most define its current economic character, indicating a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or hire. With an employment growth rate of -0.55% YoY, the city is experiencing a contraction in job opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.55% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.174% signal a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city's labor market is not adding new jobs, and the existing workforce is shouldering more responsibility. The labor demand composite score of 3.36, ranking in the bottom tier at 14th percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% is relatively low, ranking in the 66th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the low unemployment rate means that it may be harder to find available workers, and there may be upward pressure on wages to attract top talent. However, the rate is not extremely low, suggesting that there is still some flexibility in the labor market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.51% is relatively fast, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating rising labor costs for employers. This rapid wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $223/sqft and an earnings ratio of $35.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.24, is near the median, ranking 53rd percentile. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising 2.8% YoY relative to wages may make it slightly less attractive for talent attraction without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.61% YoY, indicating that the workforce supply is shrinking. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant implication for hiring capacity, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open

positions. The low labor force growth rate, ranking in the bottom tier at 12th percentile, further exacerbates this issue.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -10.45%, indicating that housing supply is tightening. This decline in building permits signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand. The low ranking of 28th percentile in building permits YoY reinforces this concern.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 44 days, with a YoY direction of +0.0%, indicating a relatively stable market. For a worker relocating to this city, the days on market suggests a moderately competitive market, neither extremely fast nor slow. The ranking of 35th percentile in days on market suggests that the market is not extremely favorable for buyers or sellers.

Office Economy

The city's professional talent pool is relatively shallow, ranking 24th percentile, indicating a smaller share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a mixed bag for businesses, with low labor demand and labor force growth posing significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the shrinking labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support business expansion or hiring. Despite some positive metrics, such as fast wage growth and a relatively low unemployment rate, the city's overall economic character is defined by its labor market constraints.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

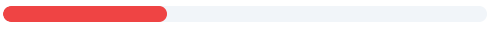
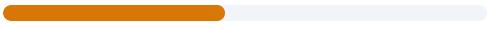
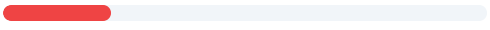
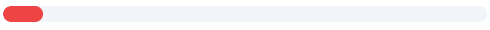
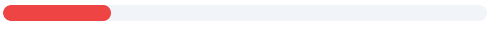
C

VERY POOR

39.9th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		34
Unemployment 20% weight		46
Wage Growth 15% weight		22
Cost of Living 12% weight		8
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		64
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		82
Days on Market 5% weight		22
Office Economy 3% weight		72

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+1.9%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.5%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+27.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
56 days
median, -3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 39.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.80, which is below average at the 34th percentile. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high cost of living, with a cost of living ratio of $494/sqft to $40.91/hr, resulting in a ratio of 12.08, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. The combination of low labor demand and high cost of living presents a challenging environment for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in New York Newark-Jersey City is +0.50% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.202% below trend, indicating a labor demand composite score that signals a contraction in genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a slowdown in job growth, with hours worked below the 12-month baseline. The labor market is not demonstrating strong demand for workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in New York Newark-Jersey City is 4.70%, which is near the median at the 46th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant slack nor tightness. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that finding qualified workers may not be overly difficult, but it also does not indicate a surplus of available labor. The market conditions are average, with no significant advantage or disadvantage.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in New York Newark-Jersey City is +1.91%, which is below average at the 22nd percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. The slow wage growth may help keep labor costs in check, but it also suggests a lack of upward pressure on wages.

Cost of Living

New York Newark-Jersey City has a cost of living ratio of $494/sqft to $40.91/hr, resulting in a ratio of 12.08, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating that the city is expensive relative to peers. The low percentile rank means that the city is less affordable, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living is a significant disadvantage for businesses trying to recruit workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in New York Newark-Jersey City is growing at a rate of -0.15% year-over-year, which is above average at the 64th percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. Although the growth rate is negative, its above-average percentile rank suggests that the contraction is relatively mild compared to other cities. The implication for hiring capacity is that the labor pool is shrinking, presenting a structural headwind for businesses trying to expand their workforce.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in New York Newark-Jersey City is +27.93%, which is in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This rapid growth in building permits signals that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The strong growth in permits is a positive sign for the city's future housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market in New York Newark-Jersey City is 56 days, with a year-over-year change of -3.5%, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. The below-average percentile rank of 22nd percentile means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. The fast-paced market may make it difficult for workers to find homes, potentially affecting their decision to relocate.

Office Economy

New York Newark-Jersey City has an office economy percentile rank of 72nd percentile, indicating a deep professional talent pool. The city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries that rely on industrial or logistics workers.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area presents a mixed bag for businesses, with a strong office economy and expanding housing supply, but also a high cost of living and slow wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs and affecting profitability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #36 OF 50

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

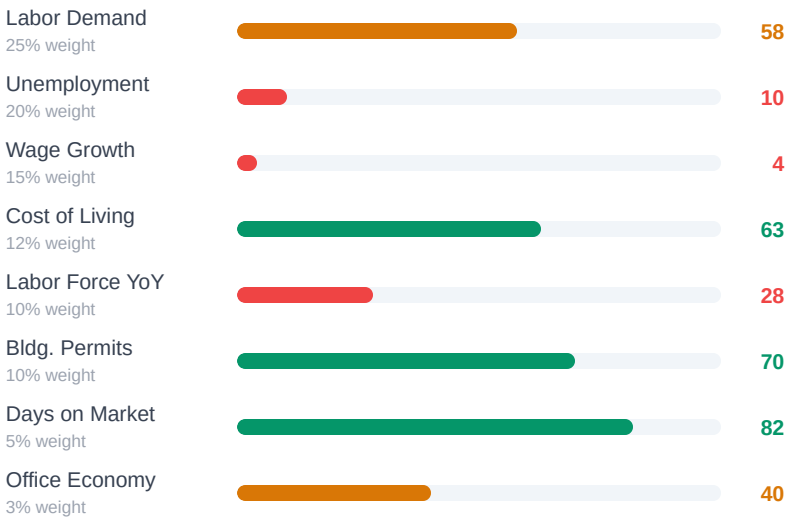
C

VERY POOR

39.8th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.3%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+18.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **42 days** median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 39.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.57. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.70% and stagnant wage growth of +0.27% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a tight labor market with limited room for wage growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +1.39% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.671% below the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a moderate expansion in job numbers, but with hours worked below trend, indicating some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.57 is near the median, suggesting a balanced but not particularly strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. Businesses looking to hire in this market may face challenges in finding available talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.27%, which is in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. This could have implications for businesses relying on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score that ranks in the 63rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $206/sqft to $40.75/hr, indicating that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -2.4% year-over-year relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability. This makes the city more attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is shrinking at a rate of -1.77% year-over-year, which is below average at the 28th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract talent from other areas.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has increased by +18.45% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city is likely to remain attractive to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this also suggests a less competitive market for sellers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington ranks near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. This city is suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy but may not be the best fit for those requiring a deeply specialized tech or finance talent pool.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding housing supply, which could attract talent without significant wage premiums. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market with low unemployment and stagnant wage growth, which may limit hiring capacity and drive up labor costs over time.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

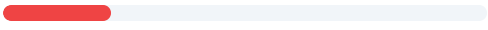
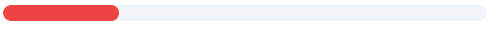
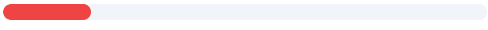
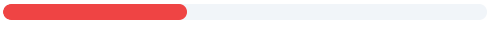
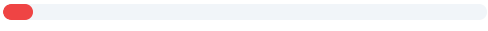
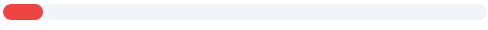
C

VERY POOR

38.9th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand (25% weight)		62
Unemployment (20% weight)		22
Wage Growth (15% weight)		24
Cost of Living (12% weight)		18
Labor Force YoY (10% weight)		38
Bldg. Permits (10% weight)		88
Days on Market (5% weight)		6
Office Economy (3% weight)		8

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
5.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+2.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.5%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+30.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
51 days
median, -8.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and cost of living metrics. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.87, which combines a 0.76% employment growth rate and a 0.508% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the cost of living, with a PSF of $340/sqft and an hourly wage of $38.44, resulting in a ratio of 8.84, ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.76% and weekly hours deviation of 0.508% above trend signal genuine demand expansion in the Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.87, ranking in the 62nd percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 5.20%, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that while it may be somewhat challenging for businesses to hire, the market is not extremely competitive, and wage pressure is moderate. Businesses looking to hire in this market should be prepared for some competition, but it is not as intense as in other cities.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 2.02%, ranking in the 24th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not dramatically. As a result, businesses should expect to see some upward pressure on wages, but it is not a major concern.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom, with a PSF of $340/sqft and an hourly wage of $38.44, resulting in a ratio of 8.84, ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive market. This means that the city is less attractive for talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may deter some workers from relocating. Businesses looking to attract top talent may need to offer higher salaries to compensate for the expensive cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.54% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction suggests that the city's workforce supply is decreasing, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses should be prepared for a potentially challenging hiring environment.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has increased by 30.25% year-over-year, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating a significant expansion of housing supply. This growth suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is expected to increase, which may improve affordability and workforce accommodation. As a result, the city's housing market is likely to become more accessible to workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 51 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.9%, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. This means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. Businesses should be prepared to offer relocation assistance or flexible housing options to attract top talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 0.78, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industrial or logistics sectors.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a labor market with genuine demand expansion, but also poses challenges due to its relatively expensive cost of living and shrinking labor pool. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract top talent, making it essential to carefully consider the trade-offs when evaluating this location for business expansion or relocation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

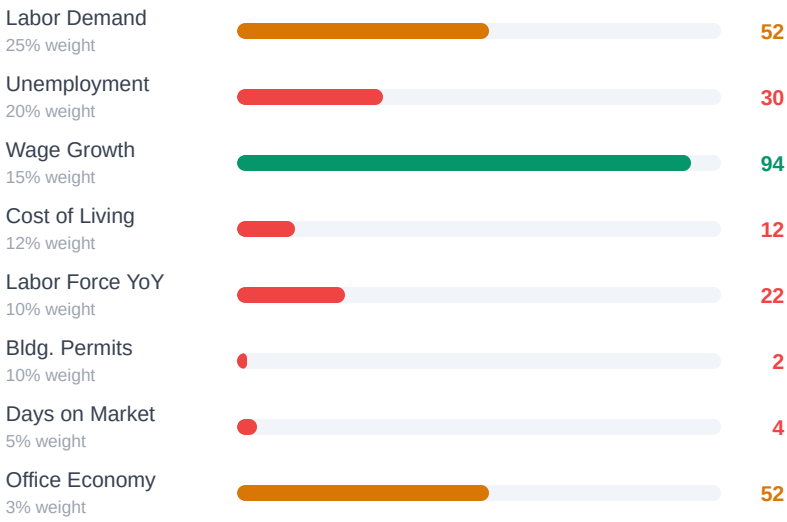
C

VERY POOR

38.7th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-36.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **46 days** median, -6.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its high wage growth and low cost of living affordability. The city's economic character is most notably marked by a 94th percentile wage growth rate of +7.50% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of $587/sqft to $44.28/hr, which places it in the 12th percentile for affordability. This combination suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to manage labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is +0.70% year-over-year, combined with a +0.152% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.43. This signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The combination of job growth and hours above trend suggests that the labor market is experiencing genuine demand, rather than a survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.90%, placing it in the 30th percentile, which indicates a below-average labor market tightness. This means that while there is some slack in the market, it may still pose challenges for businesses trying to hire, particularly in certain sectors. The practical implication is that businesses may face moderate competition for talent, but not to the extent seen in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is +7.50%, ranking in the 94th percentile, which is significantly above the national average. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also strong worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a skilled and affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living ratio of $587/sqft to $44.28/hr, placing it in the 12th percentile for affordability, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The PSF has fallen by -3.5% year-over-year, but this has not been enough to improve the city's affordability ranking. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living could be a deterrent for some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has contracted by -2.06% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their

recruitment strategies to attract talent from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has fallen by -36.38% year-over-year, ranking in the 2nd percentile, which signals a significant tightening of the housing supply. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 46 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -6.1%, placing it in the 4th percentile. This indicates a highly competitive market, where homes are selling quickly. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that the housing market is challenging, with limited time to make a decision on a property.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has an office economy percentile rank of 52, indicating a near median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for a variety of businesses, but may not have the same level of specialization as other metros. The city is likely well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be the best fit for industries requiring a highly specialized or unique talent pool.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and affluent workforce, with strong wage growth and a competitive labor market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living and tightening housing supply, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums and adapt their recruitment strategies to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

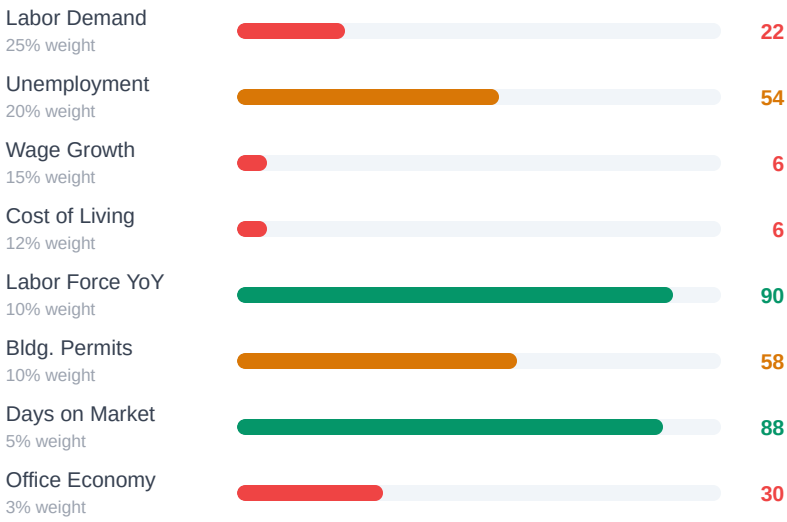
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VERY POOR

38.0th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+13.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **37 days** median, +12.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38th out of 50 US metros, with a composite score that reflects a mix of challenges and opportunities. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.95, and its stagnant wage growth, at +0.52% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city that is struggling to create new job opportunities and facing downward pressure on wages.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.25% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.588% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city experiencing a decline in both jobs and hours worked. As a result, businesses may face a challenging environment for growth and expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.80%, which is near the median, ranking 54th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but also indicating weaker local consumer demand. However, the relatively low unemployment rate may still lead to some wage pressure, as workers have a degree of bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +0.52%, which is stagnant and ranks in the bottom tier, at the 6th percentile. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but also means that workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but may also struggle to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier, at the 6th percentile, with a PSF of $228/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.76, resulting in a ratio of 6.38. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 2.2% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability challenge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +1.57% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate, ranking 90th percentile. This expansion in labor supply is a positive sign for businesses, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers and a

reduced risk of labor shortages.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +13.52% year-over-year, which is a near-median growth rate, ranking 58th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is investing in new housing stock and preparing for population growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.1%, ranking in the top tier, at the 88th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively fast days on market still indicates a competitive market, and businesses may need to offer relocation assistance to attract top talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 2.06, which ranks below average, at the 30th percentile. This indicates that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

In conclusion, Milwaukee-Waukesha offers businesses a mix of challenges and opportunities, with a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, but also stagnant wage growth and a relatively expensive cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the lack of labor demand and the resulting downward pressure on wages, which may limit growth and expansion opportunities.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

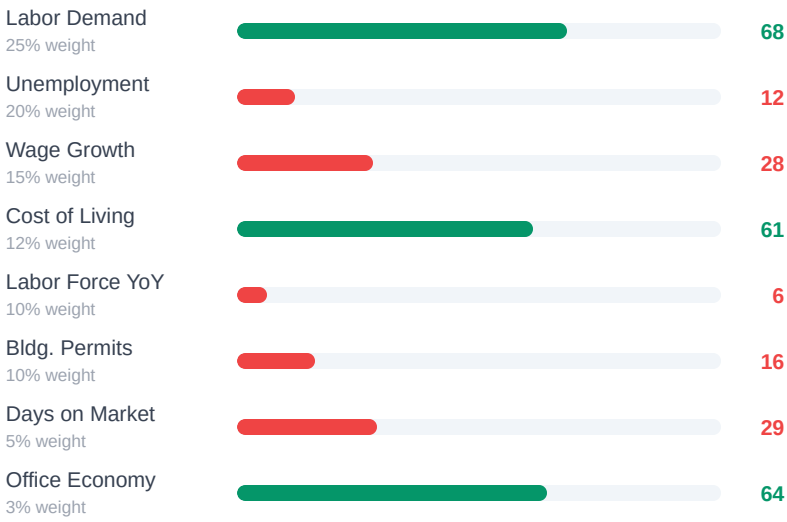
C-

CRITICAL

36.5th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.6%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-3.0%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-19.6%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **58 days** median, -3.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 36.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score of 5.94 ranking it in the 68th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 4.60%, which ranks it in the 12th percentile. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some indicators pointing to growth and others to challenges.

Labor Demand

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.10% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.564% from its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.94, ranking in the 68th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 4.60%, ranking it in the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +2.15%, ranking it in the 28th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. Workers in the area will see some increase in their purchasing power, but it may not be as strong as in other metros.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score ranking it in the 61st percentile, with a PSF of $279/sqft and average hourly earnings of $43.51/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.41. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a falling PSF (-3.1% YoY) contributing to its high affordability score. This makes it an attractive location for talent, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -2.99% year-over-year, ranking it in the 6th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a significant challenge for businesses looking to hire, as it may lead to a shortage of skilled workers. The implications for hiring capacity are negative, making it harder for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial has decreased by -19.62% year-over-year, ranking it in the 16th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area. This is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady influx of new talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 58 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.3%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the 29th percentile, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, this could also suggest a strong demand for housing, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a professional and office worker share of 2.92, ranking it in the 64th percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, making it an attractive location for businesses in these sectors. However, it may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers a mixed economic environment, with some indicators pointing to growth and others to challenges. While the city has a relatively affordable cost of living and a deep professional talent pool, its high unemployment rate, shrinking labor force, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks for businesses looking to locate there. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which could lead to a shortage of skilled workers and make it harder for companies to find the talent they need.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

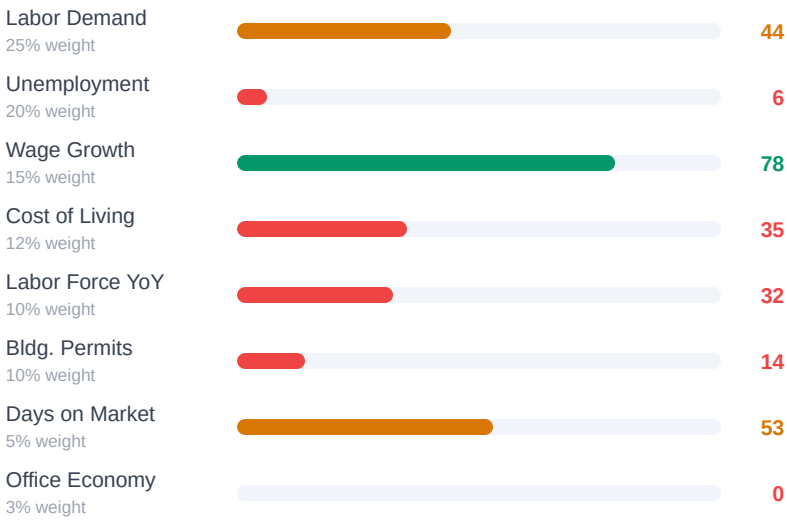
C-

CRITICAL

35.3th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **5.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.7%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-20.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **64 days** median, -4.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 35.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth and low unemployment rate, with a wage growth rate of 5.51% and an unemployment rate of 5.90%. The combination of these metrics suggests a competitive labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 0.75% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.149% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand but not excessively strong. The labor demand composite score of 5.20 ranks near the median at 44th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at 6th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.51%, ranking above average at 78th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score ranking below average at 35th percentile, with a PSF of $330/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.45/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.31. The PSF is falling -1.5% year-over-year, making the city relatively less affordable compared to peers. This may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -1.74% year-over-year, ranking below average at 32nd percentile. This implies a shrinking labor pool, creating a structural headwind for hiring and potentially limiting business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is falling -19.99% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 14th percentile. This signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 64 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.5%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, making it competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the market is still accessible, with homes selling relatively quickly.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a professional and office worker share ranking in the bottom tier at 0th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a competitive labor market with high wage growth, but also presents challenges such as a tight labor market and decreasing affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool, which may limit business growth and require strategic hiring and talent retention strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

Richmond

Richmond

C-

CRITICAL

35.3th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	8
Unemployment	20% weight	66
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	29
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	14
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	96
Days on Market	5% weight	10
Office Economy	3% weight	22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+2.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-2.6%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+83.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
44 days
median, -4.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 35.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 2.93, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its high building permits growth, with a year-over-year change of +83.77%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. These metrics signal a city with struggling job market fundamentals but strong developer confidence.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.82% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.219%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as hours are slightly above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers to fill new positions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.60%, which ranks in the above-average tier at the 66th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire new workers. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +2.40%, which is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may impact businesses' ability to attract and retain workers, as they may need to balance wage growth with other benefits.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score that ranks in the 29th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $226/sqft to $35.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.29. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it less attractive for talent attraction without wage premiums. Businesses may need to consider offering higher salaries to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is shrinking at a rate of -2.57% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing, making it more challenging for businesses to find skilled workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Richmond is +83.77%, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 96th percentile. This rapid growth in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and workforce accommodation in the future. This is a positive signal for businesses considering relocation, as it may lead to a more stable and affordable housing market for their workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Richmond is 44 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.3%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The decreasing days on market suggests that the market is becoming even more competitive, which may impact businesses' ability to attract and retain workers.

Office Economy

Richmond has an office economy score that ranks in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Richmond metro area offers businesses a unique combination of struggling job market fundamentals and strong developer confidence, with a rapidly expanding housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and contracting labor supply, which may make it challenging to find and retain skilled workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

Memphis

Memphis

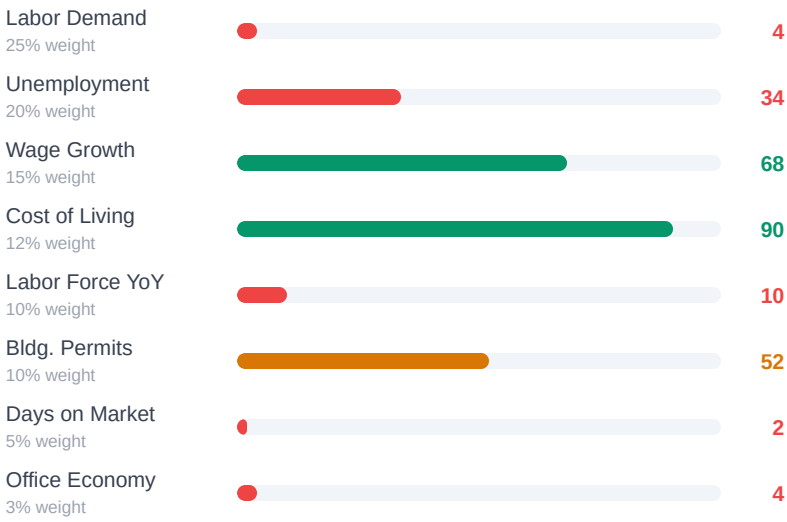
C-

CRITICAL

35.2th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.6%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+5.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **72 days** median, +7.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 35.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high cost of living affordability, ranking in the top tier with a score of 90th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 2.11 and the cost of living ratio of $153/sqft to $33.22/hr, with a PSF decline of 2.5% YoY, are key metrics shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.49% YoY and weekly hours 1.586% above its own trend, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.11 is in the bottom tier, ranking 4th percentile, which further supports the notion of a struggling labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.60%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

Memphis experiences a year-over-year wage growth of +4.52%, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, leading to rising labor costs for employers but also increasing worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering Memphis as a location.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living score in the top tier at the 90th percentile, Memphis is more affordable relative to its peers, given its PSF of $153/sqft and hourly earnings of $33.22, resulting in a ratio of 4.61. The 2.5% YoY decline in PSF further enhances affordability. This makes Memphis attractive for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums, offering a competitive advantage in talent attraction.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is shrinking at a rate of -2.77% YoY, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses should consider this trend when assessing their hiring capacity in the city.

Building Permits

Memphis sees a year-over-year increase in building permits of +5.41%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future. However, the current pace is moderate, and its impact on future affordability and workforce attraction will depend on sustained growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Memphis is 72 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.5%. This ranks in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile, indicating a slower market where homes sit longer before being sold. For workers relocating to Memphis, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, potentially easing the relocation process.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, Memphis might be more accommodating to industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a potentially accessible housing market, but it is constrained by low labor demand, a shrinking labor force, and a limited professional talent pool. The single biggest risk for a decision-maker considering Memphis is the challenge of finding and retaining skilled workers due to the city's contracting labor supply and shallow professional talent pool.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

Fresno

Fresno

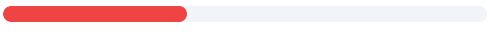
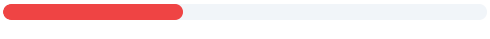
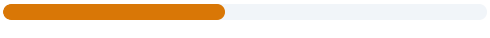
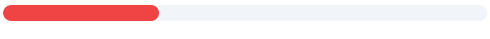
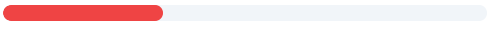
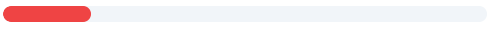
C-

CRITICAL

33.8th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand (25% weight)		38
Unemployment (20% weight)		0
Wage Growth (15% weight)		66
Cost of Living (12% weight)		37
Labor Force YoY (10% weight)		46
Bldg. Permits (10% weight)		32
Days on Market (5% weight)		33
Office Economy (3% weight)		18

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
7.8%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+4.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.3%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-6.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
58 days
median, -1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 33.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 7.80% and its below-average labor demand composite score of 4.90, which signals a challenging labor market. Specifically, the combination of low employment growth and below-trend weekly hours suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is +0.79% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.503% below its own trend, indicating a lack of genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is not experiencing a significant increase in labor demand, which may be a challenge for businesses looking to hire. The below-trend hours also imply that existing workers are not seeing a significant increase in their workloads.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.80%, which is the lowest percentile rank, indicating a significant amount of slack in the labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the high unemployment rate. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of high unemployment on their customer base.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Fresno is +4.51% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking 66th percentile. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of rising wages on their labor costs and pricing strategies.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score that ranks 37th percentile, with a PSF of $263/sqft and average hourly earnings of $34.06/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.72. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 1.1% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability concerns.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Fresno is contracting at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year, which is near the median. This suggests that the supply of workers is shrinking, which may create a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a shrinking labor pool on their hiring plans.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Fresno is decreasing by -6.89% year-over-year, which is below average. This suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 58 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.7%. This suggests that the housing market is relatively competitive, but still accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the decreasing trend may indicate a shift towards a more competitive market, which could make it challenging for workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Fresno has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking 18th percentile in terms of office and professional worker share. This suggests that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

In conclusion, Fresno offers a unique combination of a relatively low-cost business environment and a challenging labor market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in Fresno is the high unemployment rate and the tightening housing market, which may create challenges in attracting and retaining talent. As a result, businesses should carefully consider these factors when making their location decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

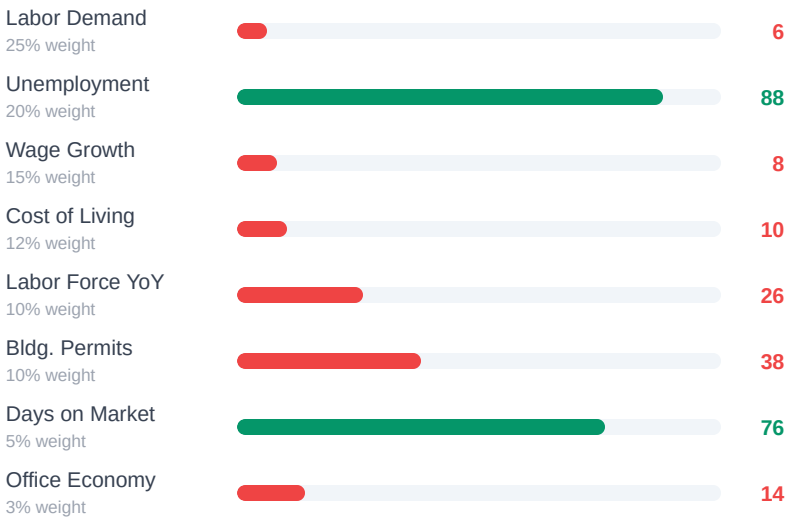
C-

CRITICAL

32.1th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.6%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-1.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-3.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **53 days** median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 32.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.30% ranking it in the top tier. The combination of these metrics, particularly the low employment growth rate of -1.05% and the low wage growth rate of +0.58%, suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.05% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.471%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are slightly above trend despite job losses. This scenario may indicate a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.30%, ranking it in the top tier with an 88th percentile score. This tight market implies that there is little slack in the labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that they may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.58%, which is relatively stagnant. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but they may also not see a significant boost in consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score in the bottom tier, with a 10th percentile rank, indicating that it is relatively expensive. The city's PSF is $165/sqft, with a ratio of 4.87 to average hourly earnings of $33.86, and is increasing by 4.4% year-over-year. This means that the city is less attractive for talent without wage premiums, as the high cost of living may offset any potential benefits of relocating to the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year. This decline in labor force supply implies that the city's hiring capacity is shrinking, making it a structural headwind for businesses looking to expand or relocate. As a result, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain top talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is decreasing by 3.35% year-over-year. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or other benefits to attract top talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 53 days, with a year-over-year increase of 12.8%. This relatively slow market, with a 76th percentile rank, means that homes are sitting on the market for longer periods, making it more accessible for workers to relocate to the area. However, this may also indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a sign of weak demand.

Office Economy

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This means that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with low unemployment, but also presents challenges such as low labor demand, slow wage growth, and a relatively high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the city's shrinking labor force supply, which may make it difficult to attract and retain top talent, and the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

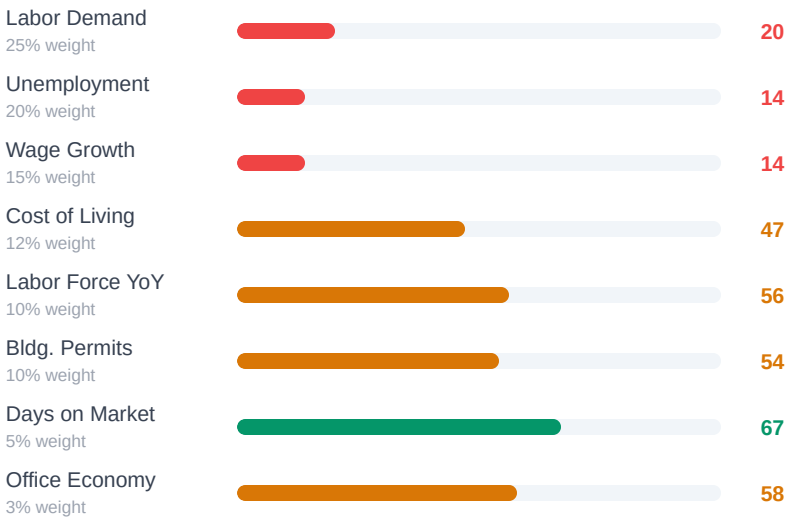
C-

CRITICAL

31.6th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.3%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+8.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **66 days** median, -12.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand composite score of 3.86, ranking it in the 20th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 4.80%, ranking it in the 14th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging labor market with limited job growth and high unemployment.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is a modest +0.06% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.520% from its own 12-month trend. This combination signals a labor market with limited genuine demand expansion, as the slight job growth is not accompanied by an increase in working hours. Instead, it may indicate a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate stands at 4.80%, ranking it in the 14th percentile, indicating a labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Jacksonville may find it relatively easier to staff, but may also face weaker local consumer demand due to the high number of unemployed individuals.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Jacksonville is +1.34% year-over-year, ranking it in the 14th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but it also translates to weak bargaining power for workers and limited growth in purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $213/sqft to $37.45/hr, Jacksonville ranks in the 47th percentile in terms of affordability. This near-median ranking means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive, but its cost of living is relatively stable. The fact that PSF is falling -1.4% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability, making it easier for businesses to attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is contracting at a rate of -0.56% year-over-year, ranking it in the 56th percentile. This decline in labor force supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of available workers is shrinking.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Jacksonville are increasing by +8.24% year-over-year, ranking it in the 54th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it indicates that developers are confident in the city's growth prospects.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Jacksonville is 66 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -12.0%, ranking it in the 67th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales means that workers relocating to the city may face a competitive market, making it challenging to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share ranks in the 58th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This makes the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional roles, but it may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

In conclusion, Jacksonville offers businesses a labor market with some challenges, including high unemployment and slow wage growth, but also some opportunities, such as a relatively stable cost of living and expanding housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in Jacksonville is the shrinking labor force, which may limit their ability to hire and grow in the long term.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #47 OF 50

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

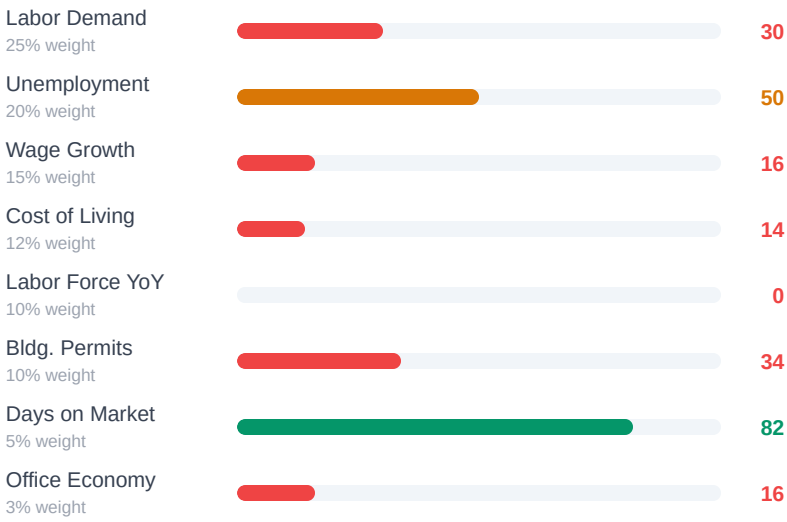
D

EMERGENCY

29.6th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.2%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-7.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-5.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **42 days** median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 29.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and stagnant wage growth, specifically a labor demand composite score of 4.59 and wage growth of +1.41% YoY. The city's labor market is characterized by slow employment growth and declining weekly hours, signaling a lack of genuine demand expansion. With a labor force growth rate of -7.20% YoY, the city's workforce supply is contracting.

Labor Demand

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.68% YoY, but weekly hours are deviating -0.658% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a lack of genuine demand expansion. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than a survivor squeeze, as hours are not increasing to absorb eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 4.59 is below average, ranking 30th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.20%, near the median of the 50 US metros, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant tightness nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that hiring may not be overly challenging, but wage pressure is not entirely absent either. The market's near-median unemployment rate suggests a stable, though not highly competitive, environment for recruitment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +1.41%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means weak bargaining power for workers, potentially affecting their purchasing power. For businesses, the slow wage growth could be seen as a cost advantage, but it may also reflect a lack of economic dynamism.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, with a PSF of $215/sqft and average hourly earnings of $32.58/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.60. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, as the PSF is rising +1.9% YoY. The low affordability score means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging, as the cost of living is high relative to earnings.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -7.20% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This significant decline in labor force growth poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses looking to expand or establish operations in this city may face challenges in finding sufficient skilled workers due to the contracting labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -5.72%, indicating that housing supply is tightening. This decline in building permits signals a potential future affordability crisis and suggests that the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce may be compromised. As housing supply fails to keep pace with demand, affordability and attractiveness for relocating workers may suffer.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home and the market is less competitive.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions. This city is better suited for businesses that do not require a large pool of specialized office workers, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers a business environment with relatively slow wage growth and a contracting labor force, posing significant challenges for hiring and expansion. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering this location is the shrinking labor pool, which could severely limit the city's ability to support business growth and attract necessary talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #48 OF 50

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

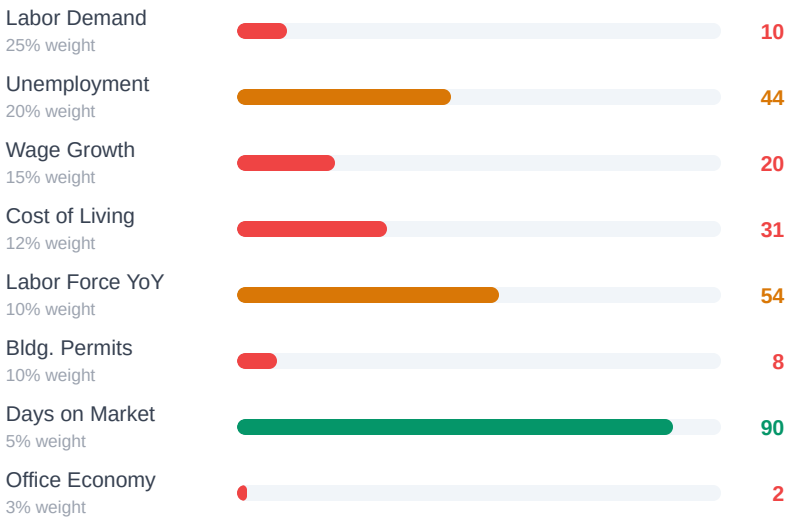
D

EMERGENCY

28.7th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.1%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-31.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **45 days** median, +12.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 28.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.98, which falls in the bottom tier. The city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with employment growth of -0.13% YoY, and its slow wage growth, at +1.74% YoY. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.13% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +1.140%, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.98 falls in the bottom tier, at the 10th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.10%, which is near the median, ranking at the 44th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but still with some wage pressure. However, the relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros may also indicate weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.74%, which is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile. This slow wage growth signals a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but also weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score that ranks at the 31st percentile, with a PSF of $178/sqft and average hourly earnings of $31.41, resulting in a ratio of 5.67. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it less attractive for talent without wage premiums. The fact that PSF is not falling YoY also suggests that affordability is not improving.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is contracting at a rate of -0.83% YoY, which is near the median, ranking at the 54th percentile. This signals a shrinking labor pool, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses may face challenges in finding and retaining talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by -31.05% YoY, which is in the bottom tier, ranking at the 8th percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Louisville-Jefferson County is currently 45 days, with a YoY increase of +12.5%, ranking at the 90th percentile. This suggests a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also indicate a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.32, ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively flat cost environment and a slower housing market, but it also presents significant challenges, including a shrinking labor pool and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's weak labor demand and slow wage growth, which may limit business expansion and talent attraction.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

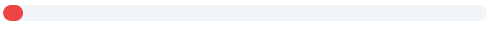
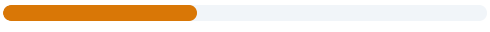
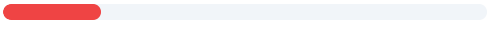
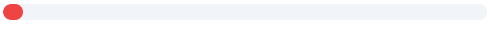
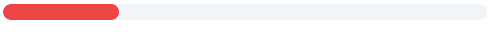
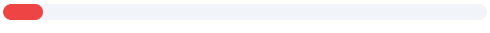
D

EMERGENCY

26.5th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		50
Unemployment 20% weight		4
Wage Growth 15% weight		40
Cost of Living 12% weight		20
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		4
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		24
Days on Market 5% weight		8
Office Economy 3% weight		50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
5.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+3.3%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-3.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-15.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
36 days
median, -5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 26.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.43. This city's economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 5.20% and its negative labor force growth rate of -3.13% YoY, indicating significant challenges in the job market. The combination of these metrics suggests a struggling economy with limited job opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.22% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.823% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score near the median. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are running above trend during a period of slow job growth. However, the overall labor demand remains near the median, indicating a lack of strong momentum.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 5.20%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This indicates a slack labor market with significant unemployment, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.28%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. Workers in the area will see some improvement in their purchasing power, but the moderate growth rate may not be enough to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score in the 20th percentile, with a PSF of $220/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.65/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.84. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, ranking below average in terms of affordability. The 3.3% YoY increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -3.13% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction will create a structural headwind for hiring, making it more difficult for businesses to find and retain workers. The declining labor force will also limit the city's ability to support economic growth and expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has decreased by -15.18% YoY, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in building permits signals a potential supply squeeze in the future, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 36 days, with a -5.3% YoY change, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. However, the bottom-tier ranking at the 8th percentile suggests that homes are still selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. The fast-paced market may lead to increased competition for limited housing options.

Office Economy

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a professional and office worker share of 2.54, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may not be as attractive to businesses requiring a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost labor market with moderate wage growth, but it is constrained by a high unemployment rate, declining labor force, and limited housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's struggling economy and limited job opportunities, which may impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

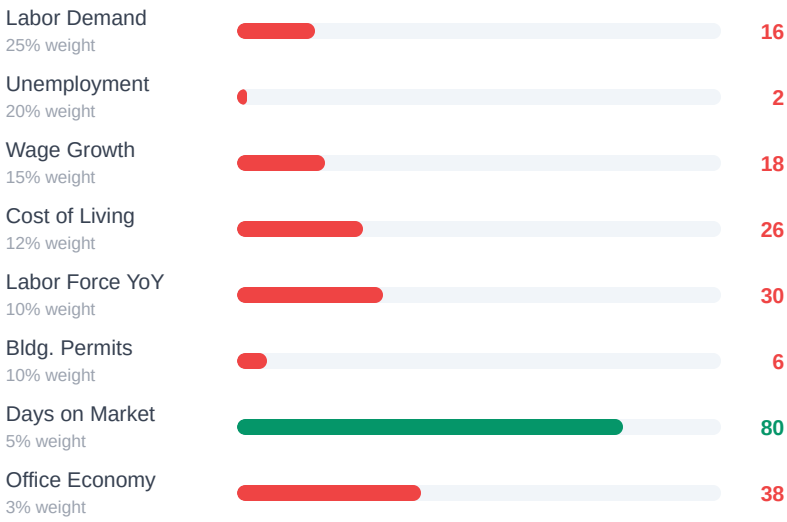
D

EMERGENCY

19.0th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **5.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-33.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **43 days** median, +7.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 19.0th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.58. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 5.70% and its negative employment growth rate of -0.20%. The combination of these metrics signals a challenging labor market for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.20%, indicating a contraction in job opportunities, while the weekly hours deviation from trend is +0.439%, suggesting that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, characteristic of a survivor squeeze. This combination signals that the labor market is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.58 falls in the bottom tier, at the 16th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.70%, which is relatively high, indicating that the labor market has some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker. The unemployment rate ranks in the bottom tier, at the 2nd percentile, suggesting significant challenges in the labor market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.48%, which is relatively slow. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The wage growth rate ranks in the bottom tier, at the 18th percentile.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score that ranks in the 26th percentile, with a PSF of $186/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.53/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.96. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The cost of living is not a significant advantage for talent attraction without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is contracting at a rate of -1.76% year-over-year, indicating that the workforce supply is shrinking. This contraction implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring and expanding their operations. The labor force growth rate ranks below average, at the 30th percentile.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -32.95%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This decline signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, potentially leading to a supply squeeze.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.5%. This increase indicates a slower market, ranking in the 80th percentile, which may be more accessible for workers relocating to the city.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is relatively low, ranking in the 38th percentile. This suggests that the city has a less deep talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, making it less suited for HQ decisions or knowledge-economy driven businesses.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a labor market with some slack, potentially making it easier to hire workers, but the slow wage growth and declining labor force supply are significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and shrinking workforce, which may limit business expansion and growth opportunities.